

Tomorrow's Child

September 2010

\$8.00 Vol. 19, No. 1

A Publication of
The Montessori
Foundation

The
International
Magazine for
Montessori
Families

In collaboration with



Highlights

*Montessori Basics • Finding
Motivation the Montessori Way •
Ecoliteracy • Parenting • Graduates
• Book Reviews ... and more!*

Announcing 3 **NEW** titles for our popular parent education pamphlet series



Ever wish for something to hand out at community events or open houses that easily explained or visually showed some aspect of Montessori that didn't overwhelm the reader? Who better than the people who wrote the book, *The Montessori Way*, to introduce such a product!

NINE Montessori pamphlets now available. Use the form below to order.



Each pamphlet bundle contains **50** of the same title and is incredibly affordable at **\$15 USD per bundle plus postage**. The items are in stock and ready to ship. They may be purchased the following ways:

1. Through our online publication center located at the Foundation's website: **www.montessori.org** (go to 'Publications,' then to 'bookstore')
2. By calling Margot at **800 632 4121** (IMC school members receive a discount on this item and will need to call with credit card. Should your IMC school membership need to be renewed, we will do that at the same time.)
3. Use this order form and either mail or fax your order. **Make checks payable to: The Montessori Foundation and mail to 19600 E State Road 64, Bradenton, FL 34212 USA. Fax number is 941 359 8166.**

Please select: USPS Flat Rate Priority or expedited courier service, such as FEDEX/UPS, which can be substantially more expensive (price is determined by weight and location by the courier). We will estimate this for you before charging out). Couriers cannot deliver to a PO BOX.

- | | | |
|--|-------------------------|--------------------|
| 1. <i>What is Montessori?</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |
| 2. <i>Why would you start your three-year-old in school?</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |
| 3. <i>Montessori Nurtures Curiosity, Creativity & Imagination</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |
| 4. <i>What can Montessori offer our infants & toddlers?</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |
| 5. <i>Creating a Culture of Partnership, Kindness, Respect & Peace</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |
| 6. <i>The Importance of Montessori for the Kindergarten Year</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |
| 7. <i>Joyful Scholars: Montessori for the Elementary Years</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |
| 8. <i>Research & Montessori</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |
| 9. <i>Montessori in the Home</i> | _____ #of bundles @\$15 | Total due \$ _____ |

Shipping Method: ☐ USPS FLAT RATE PRIORITY ☐ COURIER (FedEx/UPS)

Shipping Amount \$ _____

☐ 1 - 3 bundles \$5.95 ☐ 4 - 12 bundles \$10.95 ☐ 13+ bundles \$12.95

TOTAL DUE \$ _____

IMC membership number _____ for discounted pricing of \$12.50 per bundle. To obtain shipping-cost information for orders outside US, call 941-309-3961 or email: margot@montessori.org. (Note: We do not accept Discover cards.)

Credit card# _____ Name on Card _____ Exp. date _____

EMAIL address where receipt should be sent _____ (please print clearly)

Mailing address and name of contact person _____ (please print clearly)

Phone number in case we have a question(_____) _____

Tomorrow's Child

September 2010

Vol. 19 No. 1



Send all correspondence to:

The Montessori Foundation

19600 E State Road 64 • Bradenton, FL 34212-8921

Phone: 941-729-9565/1-800-655-5843

Fax: 941-745-3111

www.montessori.org

Tomorrow's Child (ISSN 1071-6246), published five times a year, is the official magazine of The Montessori Foundation, a non-profit organization. The opinions expressed in *Tomorrow's Child* editorials, columns, and features are those of the authors and do not necessarily represent the position of the magazine or The Montessori Foundation. Acceptance of advertising does not represent the Foundation's endorsement of any product or service.

It is the policy of The Montessori Foundation, a non-profit organization, to encourage support for the organization by discounting the sale of bulk-order shipments of *Tomorrow's Child* in order that schools may make the magazine available to their families. The Montessori Foundation does NOT grant permission to reprint material from *Tomorrow's Child* in any other form (e.g., book, newsletter, journal). Copies of this issue or back issues are available for purchase through our online Bookstore: www.montessori.org. For Standing Bulk Orders call 800-655-5843 (toll free), use the order form on page 37, or place your order at www.montessori.org. The Montessori Foundation does not provide refunds for cancelled standing bulk orders.

Conferences & Workshops, IMC – Margot Garfield-Anderson:

Phone: 941-309-3961/Toll Free: 800-632-4121/Fax: 941-359-8166
email: margot@montessori.org

Past Issues, Books & CD Orders

For immediate service, use our secure online bookstore at www.montessori.org. For questions regarding an order, email: michaelanderson@montessori.org or phone 941-309-3961/Toll Free: 800-632-4121

Subscriptions & Bookkeeping - Don Dinsmore:

Phone: 941-729-9565/1-800-655-5843
Fax: 941-745-3111
dondinsmore@montessori.org

Classified & Display Advertising - Chelsea Howe:

Phone: 410-505-3872/Fax: 941-745-3111
tcmag@montessori.org or
chelseahowe@montessori.org

Parenting Center - Lorna McGrath:

Phone: 941-729-9565/800-655-5843
Fax: 941-745-3111
lornamcgrath@montessori.org

Highlights

- 5 **The New Gate-Field School:
The Model School of The
Montessori Foundation**
- 7 **Montessori Basics**
Tim Seldin
- 12 **Montessori FAQ's**
- 15 **Finding Motivation the
Montessori Way**
Maren Schmidt
- 22 **Ecoliteracy**
Leigh Ann Carver
- 27 **Why Screen Children Entering
Montessori Schools?**
Lorna McGrath
- 28 **Separation Anxiety**
Chelsea Howe
- 31 **Coming Together:
The Community Montessori School**
Margot Garfield-Anderson
- 30 **Montessori Graduates:
Where Are They Now?**
- 33 **Dear Cathie: *Three Days is Not Enough***
- 34 **Montessori Reads**
- 36 **Classified Ads**
- 36 **Calendar**
- 37 **Tomorrow's Child Order Form**

& more...

EDITOR	Joyce St. Giermaine
PRESIDENT	Tim Seldin
PROGRAM DIRECTOR	Lorna McGrath
EVENTS & MEMBERSHIP	Margot Garfield-Anderson
BOOKKEEPER	Don Dinsmore
FULFILLMENT	Michael Anderson
PRINTED BY	InterPrint

Note: InterPrint is now FSC, SFI and PEFC Chain-of-Custody Tri-Certified. Chain-of-custody certification offers paper that has been harvested from responsibly managed forests, then verifiably traced through all stages of print production.

Information & News

Please join us ...

November 4-7, 2010

The Montessori Foundation's

14th Annual International Conference

Nurturing & Sustaining Community

Hyatt Resort, Sarasota, Florida

You're invited to attend a November 4 - 7, 2010 weekend of inspiring workshops, keynotes, entertainment, exhibitors, and, of course, the beautiful Hyatt Sarasota, Florida waterfront resort.

Our Keynote Speakers include:

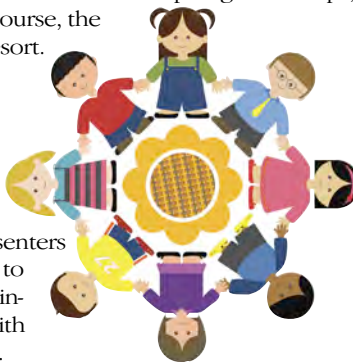
Larry Schaefer

Harvey Hallenberg

Wendy LaRue and

Tim Seldin ... along with 34 incredibly

talented and distinguished workshop presenters with a wealth of experiences and information to share with the community that will leave you inspired and ready to hit the ground running with new ideas upon your return to the classroom.



Of course, IMC members receive a generous discount on registration, so if you are not yet a member, join now through the www.montessori.org website. Then continue to watch our homepage as we continue to 'tweak' the schedule. A full conference brochure is also included with this issue.

IMC school members who bring six or more staff receive an even bigger discount! Plan now. Book flights while many airlines are running specials, and look for the Hyatt booking code in the brochure. See you there!

If you have questions, you can also call our conference hotline at 800-632-4121.

Welcome Back

By the time you receive this issue, school will be back in session. New school supplies will have been purchased. Children, parents, and teachers will be settling into their new routines. As I write this, however, life at the Foundation is anything but settled and routine.

As you will read on the next page, The Montessori Foundation was in the process of setting up a model school in Sarasota, then we merged with an existing Montessori school four weeks before the start of the school year.

Meetings, meetings, meetings and moving Montessori furniture and materials have occupied every (I was going to say 'waking' but I'm actually dreaming it as well) moment of every day as we work to blend two communities into one.

It's all good, as the kids would say, and if you are reading this sometime in September, then I did my job and finished this magazine, and by now even those of us at The Montessori Foundation will have settled into a routine and The New Gate-Field School is up and running.

Stay tuned as we "walk the walk" with our model school. It will be an exciting year for all of us.

—Joyce St. Giermaine, Editor



Keeping
*Tomorrow's
Child*

Affordable

for Families — Price for
Standing Bulk Orders

Remains the same for the
2010/11 School Year

Despite the fact that our printing and distribution costs have skyrocketed this past year, The Montessori Foundation has found a creative way to reduce our costs to publish *Tomorrow's Child*, and we're passing the savings on to our standing bulk order schools. Every Montessori school needs the validation and information that *Tomorrow's Child* provides to their families — now more than ever.

Instead of publishing the magazine five times per year, we will be reducing the number of publications to four times per year; however, instead of producing five 32-page issues, we will now produce four 40-page editions, eliminating the May issue, which many schools found to come at a time when (North American) families tend to be focused on the coming summer vacation. We save money on the cost of producing and mailing the extra issue, and schools benefit from the additional pages of content in each issue, which amounts to the same number of pages as in previous years. For more information, go to page 37.

The cost for a standing bulk order of 50 copies or more is just \$15.50 (in the US) per family (compared to the individual subscription price of \$30). If your school has fewer than 50 families, call us at 800-655-5843 to receive approval to order a smaller number.

It is our mission to provide the best information about Montessori education to as many Montessori parents as possible. Together, we'll get through this recession. This is our way to help! If you have any questions after reviewing the new production schedule and pricing, please do not hesitate to contact us at 800-655-5843/941-729-9565 or by email at tcmag@montessori.org.



One of the specially designed Montessori classroom buildings on our 100-acre campus in Sarasota, Florida. If you are planning to attend our Annual International Conference this November, tours will be available.

New Gate & Field School Merge under the Leadership of The Montessori Foundation, Making Sarasota, FL an International Site for Educational Innovation

Combining the two schools represents a merger of expertise and resources that will serve as a model for best Montessori practices for children from toddlers through high school, including plans to develop a new model Montessori International Baccalaureate program for middle and secondary students.



The NewGate-Field School
Model School of The Montessori Foundation

The Montessori Foundation is pleased to announce the joining together of The New Gate and Field Schools to form the Foundation's international model school and a Center for Montessori Educational Leadership.

This is exciting news for the future of both schools and is another milestone for The Montessori Foundation and the thousands of schools with which we work.

For many years, The Montessori Foundation led and developed The New Gate School in Sarasota, Florida into national prominence. As sometimes happens, we each went our separate ways. We, at the Montessori Foundation, expanded the scope of our work with Montessori schools around the world. New Gate completed the first phase of the master plan we developed together and built a beautiful facility. Always, we remained friends.

Those of us at The Montessori Foundation realized that, since one of our primary missions is to prepare the leaders of the world's great Montessori schools, it was important for our senior staff to always have day-to-day contact with children, teachers, and the experience of leading a large Montessori school. We concluded that The Montessori Foundation needed a model school.

Last year, we entertained discussions with New Gate's board and administration with a proposal of collaboration. The timing was not right then, but they encouraged us to begin to develop a new school of our own on the other side of the Sarasota community. As you may know, that school was The Field School, which has developed quite a following and sparked new interest in Montessori education throughout the Sarasota area.

Recently, the New Gate Board approached us in order to reopen the conversation. The timing was right, and we are very pleased to announce that The New Gate School and The Montessori Foundation have renewed their relationship, merging two schools together under the leadership of The Montessori Foundation. Montessori Foundation President, Tim Seldin, will serve as Head of School and Senior Program Officer, Lorna McGrath, will serve as the Associate Head of School.

The New Gate-Field School offers Montessori programs for children as young as eighteen months all the way through high school. Another aspect of this partnership will be the development of a national board that will include parents, representatives of The Montessori Foundation, nationally recognized Montessori leaders, and others who bring to the school strong nonprofit and business experience.

Our Model School will Explore New Ways to Deliver Montessori Best Practices to Schools around the World

As many of you know, the Montessori Foundation literally 'wrote the book' (*The Montessori Way*) on how to integrate Montessori principles into all aspects of school life, from an authentic Montessori program and curriculum at each age level, to building a strong partnership-based community, student leadership, and family-friendly policies.

For more information, contact Tim Seldin (Head of School) at timseldin@montessori.org or Lorna McGrath (Associate Head) at lornamcgrath@montessori.org or call the school's office at 941-922-4949.

As our model school, The New Gate - Field School, will offer:

A Truly International Curriculum

■ We will put the world into the palm of our students' hands, studying and celebrating the cultures and nations from which we came.

■ Our curriculum will give students both a sense of place (the history, economy, social issues, and culture of our community, state, and nation) and will delve deeply into the study of other nations from many perspectives: cultural, social, economic, political, and historical.

■ The Montessori Foundation works with schools all over the world. Our extensive connections and ongoing work has given us a solid foundation in international studies from the years of early childhood through high school graduation.

■ Some lessons will be taught 'live' on two-way video links by outstanding educators around the world.

■ Elementary and Upper School students will be able to meet and collaborate by two-way video link with fellow students in Montessori schools around the world.

■ Students (and interested parents) will have opportunities for study and travel to our sister Montessori schools abroad.

■ Our goal is to develop a Montessori-International Baccalaureate program at the Upper School level.

Second Language Classes

■ Beginning with Spanish, all students will study a second language.

■ As the school grows, we will introduce additional languages or alternative language classrooms.

A Diverse School Community within an Independent School Setting

■ Our goal is to draw together children and families from all segments of the community, in an independent school, without seeking or accepting government funds.

■ In order to provide as much assistance as we can for families who could not otherwise afford to participate in this type of program, we will build funding for financial aid into our budget, while encouraging support for this innovative approach from the local community and from national sources.

Sustainability

■ We will place emphasis on creating a sustainable environment.

■ Students will have ongoing lessons on living a life that is more in harmony with a sustainable environment.

■ Each class will be setting up substantial organic gardens.

A Truly Family-Friendly School

■ We will offer Montessori extended-day programs for working families.

■ We will also offer care on days when school is not in session (except for government holidays).

■ We will offer optional summer programs, offering year-round Montessori education, language immersion, the arts, field science, and travel.

A Close-Knit Montessori Partnership-Based School Community

■ All of our administrative and board decisions will be based on clear, written, and commonly understood values and principles of Montessori partnership (the *Blueprint of Our Core Beliefs*).

■ All members of our school community (faculty, students, parents, and the leaders of the School and Montessori Foundation) will be able to participate in a partnership-based process of ongoing discussion, planning, problem solving, and self-study/program evaluation.

■ In a partnership-based Montessori community, we are a *Circle of Equals*. While all school policies and decisions will be based on The Montessori Foundation's core values and principles of Montessori Best Practice, every voice will be heard in a culture of kindness, respect, and search for the best solutions.

■ On an ongoing basis, parents, teachers, and students will be invited to participate in our monthly community meetings.

■ We will schedule many opportunities to come together as parents, students, and educators in celebration – not for an endless cycle of fund raising!

A Peace Academy

■ Just as The Montessori Foundation teaches peace and partnership skills to schools

around the world, we will teach peace-making and leadership skills to our students (and interested parents).

■ Children will learn how to communicate clearly and assertively in ways that express kindness and respect.

■ They will learn skills of conflict resolution, consensus building, and develop strong relationships.

■ They will learn about the world's great peacemakers and leaders of nonviolent social change.

■ We will encourage our students to contribute to others through a tradition of community service and philanthropy.

Cutting-Edge Use of Computer Technology and Web-Based Communication

■ Live conversations with fascinating men and women who represent relevant fields of interest, from science, technology, newsmakers, and community organizers.

■ Online learning opportunities of all sorts, from sophisticated use of the Internet to actual online learning units for Elementary and Secondary students.

■ At the Elementary and Upper School levels, everyday use of computer applications for a very wide range of writing, presentations, problem solving, data analysis, and creative work.

A School for Entrepreneurs and Leadership

■ We will teach children to be economically literate and capable.

■ We will help them to understand business and industry, as well as personal economics.

■ Elementary and Upper School students will learn about local businesses, professions, and the roles of local government from field experience and (at the Upper School level) internships.

■ Students will be encouraged and assisted in forming their own small businesses for hands on learning.

Visitors are welcome. To schedule a tour, please contact the office at 941-922 4949.

Montessori Basics

Some Basic Information that Every Montessori Parent Should Know

by Tim Seldin, President
The Montessori Foundation

Every year thousands of young children begin their education in Montessori schools around the world. Their parents ask, "Just what is this thing called Montessori?" Their questions are well founded, because Montessori schools are normally very different from the schools most of us attended when we were young. Those of us who have spent years around Montessori children know that Montessori works! Parents who are new to Montessori have to sort through a host of conflicting impressions. When friends ask them about their children's new Montessori school, most parents honestly don't know where to begin.

"It all looked so nice when we visited the school last spring. But to tell the truth, most of what the school told us about how Montessori works sailed right past us! After all, it really is a bit much to take in all at once, all this talk about the planes of development, sensitive periods, and prepared environments. And just what is it that we're supposed to call Samantha's teachers? Are they 'directresses,' 'mentors,' 'facilitators,' or are they 'guides'? Gosh, I wonder if they ever just teach?"

It all seems so terribly complicated, especially when people have such different impressions of Montessori. Some rave about it, while others think that you must be crazy to put your child in a Montessori school. Some people are firmly convinced that Montessori is too rigid and that it robs children of their creativity; others object that it is completely unstructured and without any academic standards.

"Isn't Montessori the sort of school where they allow the children to do whatever they want? Perhaps it will work for your Sally, but I'm afraid that if my Danny were left to his own devices, he'd never choose to work! He needs order, structure, a small-class size, and discipline!"

For more than thirty years, I've tried to help parents sort all this out, so they could reassure themselves that Montessori isn't going to leave their children academically handicapped and unable to make it in the 'real' world. It's still not easy to put Montessori into context, when the rest of the world seems so completely committed to a very different approach to raising children. *Montessori Basics* was written to help parents begin to discover and reconfirm what Montessori children know — Montessori works!

— Tim Seldin, President, The Montessori Foundation;
author of *How to Raise an Amazing Child* and
The World in the Palm of Her Hand;
co-author of *The Montessori Way* and *Celebrations of Life*



The Many Faces of Montessori in North America

There are more than four thousand Montessori schools in the United States and Canada and thousands more around the world. Montessori schools are found throughout Western Europe, Central and South America, Australia, New Zealand, and much of Asia.

The movement is widespread in countries such as the Netherlands, the United Kingdom, Ireland, India, Sri Lanka, Korea, and Japan, and it is beginning to expand into Eastern Europe, the republics of the former Soviet Union, and China.

There is tremendous diversity within the community of Montessori schools. Despite the impression that all Montessori schools are the same, perhaps a franchise like McDonald's™, no two Montessori schools are alike.

Across the United States and Canada, we can find Montessori schools in almost every community. They are found in church basements, converted barns, shopping centers, former public schools, and on expansive campuses with enrollments of hundreds of children and the air of stature and stability.

Editor's Note: This article is an excerpt of an old favorite, mostly to give parents new to Montessori a little background of information about the very special form of education they've chosen for their children. It's just enough to get the year started on the right foot. For more information, we urge new parents to pick up copies of *Montessori 101* (our special combined issue), *How to Raise an Amazing Child*, and *The Montessori Way*. All are available through our online bookstore at www.montessori.org.



We can find them in suburban and inner-city public-school systems. Montessori schools are often found in charming homes — the outcome of the individual vision of the owner/director. Many are found in affluent communities, but just as many serve working-class neighborhoods and the poor. We can find Montessori in Head Start programs, child-care centers in our inner cities, migrant workers' camps, and on Native American reservations.

Some Montessori schools pride themselves on remaining faithful to what they see as Dr. Maria Montessori's original vision, while others appreciate flexibility and pragmatic adaptation. Each school reflects its own unique blend of facilities, programs, personality, and interpretation of Dr. Montessori's vision.

Most Montessori schools begin with three-year-olds and extend through the elementary grades. Every year more schools open middle-school programs, infant-toddler programs, and Montessori high schools are beginning to appear more frequently.

Montessori schools offer a wide range of programs. Many are focused on meeting the needs of the working family. Others describe themselves as college-preparatory programs. Public Montessori programs pride themselves on serving all children, while many independent schools work hard to find the perfect match of student, school, and family values. The Montessori Foundation and The International Montessori Council (IMC) celebrate the diversity to be found among Montessori schools. Just as each child is unique, the schools that we create are unique communities of parents and teachers.

What makes Montessori schools different?

Montessori schools are not completely different from other schools. Over the last century, Dr. Maria Montessori's ideas have had a profound and growing influence on education around the world. However, while individual elements of her program are finding their way into more classrooms every year, there is a cumulative impact that we see when schools fully implement the entire Montessori model, which creates something quite distinct.

Here are a few key points to consider as you look at Montessori schools more closely:

- Montessori schools begin with a respect for children as unique individuals. They work from a deep concern for their social and emotional development.
- Montessori schools are warm and supportive communities of students, teachers, and parents. Children don't get lost in the crowd!
- Montessori consciously teaches children to be kind and peaceful.
- Montessori classrooms are bright and exciting environments for learning.
- Montessori classes bring children together in multi-age groups, rather than classes comprised of just one grade level. Normally, they span three age levels. Children stay with their teachers for three years. This allows teachers to develop close and long-term relationships with their pupils, allows them to know each child's learning style very well, and encourages a strong sense of community among the children. Every year, more non-Montessori schools adopt this effective strategy.
- Montessori classrooms are not run by the teachers alone. Students are taught to manage their own community and develop leadership skills and independence.
- Montessori assumes that children are born intelligent; they simply learn in different ways and progress at their own pace. The Montessori approach to education is consciously designed to recognize and address different learning styles, helping students learn to study most effectively. Students progress as they master new skills, moving ahead as quickly as they are ready.
- Montessori students rarely rely on texts and workbooks. Why? Because many of the skills and concepts that children learn are abstract, and texts simply don't bring them to life. Also, in the case of reading, many reading series fail to collect first-rate and compelling stories and essays; instead, Montessori relies upon hands-on concrete learning materials and the library, where children are introduced to the best in literature and reference materials.
- Learning is not focused on rote drill and memorization. The goal is to develop students who really understand their school-work.
- Montessori students learn through hands-on experience, investigation, and research. They become actively engaged in their studies, rather than passively waiting to be taught.
- Montessori challenges and sets high expectations for all students, not only those considered 'gifted.'
- Students develop self-discipline and an internal sense of purpose and motivation. After graduation from Montessori, these values serve them well in high school, college, and in their lives as adults.
- Montessori schools normally reflect a highly diverse student body, and their curriculum promotes mutual respect and a global perspective.
- Students develop a love for the natural world. Natural science and outdoor education is an important element of our children's experience.
- The Montessori curriculum is carefully structured and integrated to demonstrate the connections among the different subject areas. Every class teaches critical thinking, composition, and research. History lessons link architecture, the arts, science, and technology.
- Students learn to care about others through community service.
- Montessori teachers facilitate learning, coach students along, and come to know them as friends and mentors.
- Students learn not to be afraid of making mistakes; they come to see their mistakes as natural steps in the learning process.
- Montessori students learn to collaborate and work together in learning and on major projects. They strive for their personal best, rather than compete against one another for the highest grade in their class.





***Become a certified Montessori teacher.
Enroll in NAMC's Distance Learning
program and don't miss a minute of work!***

**A Teacher's Dream – Lifetime Resource Materials
are all included in one low tuition fee.**

**Infant/Toddler (0-3)
Diploma Program
seven albums including:**

- Five Most Important Ideas in Montessori
- Preparing the Montessori Environment
- Practical Life Activities
- Communicating the Montessori Way
- Recordkeeping
- Sensory Activities
- Cognitive Activities
- Being a Montessori Caregiver
- Social Activities
- Language Activities
- Materials and Equipment
- Motor Activities

**Early Childhood (3-6)
Diploma Program
six albums including:**

- 3-6 Montessori Educator's Guide to Theory and Classroom Practice
- Practical Life Activities
- Sensorial Activities including Music
- Culture and Science
- Language Arts
- Mathematics
- Over 475 Blackline Masters on CD
- Over five hours of Montessori video presentations

**Lower Elementary (6-9)
Diploma Program
fourteen albums
including:**

- Elementary Educator's Guide to Theory and Classroom Practice
- Physical Geography
- Cultural Geography
- History
- Science Experiments
- Five Great Lessons/ Cosmic Education & Peace
- Advanced Practical Life
- Botany
- Zoology
- Matter & Astronomy
- Health Sciences, Art & Music
- Language Arts – Book 1 & 2
- Math – Book 1 & 2
- Over 1,100 Blackline Masters on CD

**Upper Elementary (9-12)
Diploma Program
sixteen albums
including:**

- Elementary Educator's Guide to Theory and Classroom Practice
- Physical Geography
- Cultural Geography
- World History
- Scientific Method and Technology
- Health Sciences
- Astronomy & Ecology
- Botany & Microscopic Study
- Zoology
- US History
- Matter & Energy
- Language Arts – Book 1 & 2
- Math – Book 1, 2 & 3
- Curriculum Support Material on CD



**FOR DETAILS ON DIPLOMA PROGRAMS,
INDIVIDUAL SALES OF ALBUMS, DVD'S, AND BLACKLINE MASTERS:**

www.montessoritraining.net Toll Free: 1-877-531-6665

The Prepared Environment

Montessori classrooms tend to fascinate children and their parents. They are normally bright, warm, and inviting, filled with plants, animals, art, music, and books. There are interest centers filled with intriguing learning materials, mathematical models, maps, charts, fossils, historical artifacts, computers, scientific apparatus, perhaps a small natural-science museum, and animals that the children are raising.

Montessori classrooms are commonly referred to as a 'prepared environment.' This name reflects the care and attention that is given to creating a learning environment that will reinforce the children's independence and intellectual development.

You would not expect to find rows of desks in a Montessori classroom. The rooms are set up to facilitate student discussion and stimulate collaborative learning. One glance and it is clear that children feel comfortable and safe.



The Montessori classroom is organized into several curriculum areas, usually including: language arts (reading, literature, grammar, creative writing, spelling, and handwriting); mathematics and geometry; everyday living skills; sensory-awareness exercises and puzzles; geography; history; science; art; music; and movement. Most rooms will include a classroom library. Each area is made up of one or more shelf units, cabinets, and display tables with a wide variety of

materials on open display, ready for use as the children select them.

Students are found scattered around the classroom, working alone or with one or two others. They tend to become so involved in their work that visitors are immediately struck by the peaceful atmosphere.

It may take a moment to spot the teachers within the environment. They will normally be found working with one or two children at a time: advising, presenting a new lesson, or quietly observing the class at work.

Why do Montessori schools group children together in such large multi-age classes?



A typical Montessori class is made up of twenty-five to thirty-five children, more or less evenly divided between boys and girls, covering a three-year age span. This practice has been a hallmark of the Montessori approach for more than one hundred years. Classes are normally taught by a certified Montessori educator, teaching with one or more assistants or by two Montessori teachers.

Classes tend to be stable communities, with only the oldest third moving on to the next level each year. With two-thirds of the children returning each fall, Montessori encourages a very different level of relationship among children and their peers, as well as among children and their teachers.

The levels usually found in a Montessori school correspond to the developmental stages of childhood: Infant (birth through 18 months); Toddler (18 months to age 3); Early Childhood (age 3 to 6); Lower Elementary (age 6 to 9); Upper Elementary (age 9 to 12); Middle School (age 12 to 15); and Secondary (age 15 to 18). At each level, the program and curriculum are logical and highly consistent extensions of what has come before.

Many non-Montessori pre-schools are proud of their very small group sizes, and parents often wonder why Montessori classes are so much larger. Schools that place children together into small groups assume that the teacher is the source of instruction; a very limited resource even in a small class.

These schools reason that as the number of children decreases, the time that teachers have to spend with each child increases. Ideally, they would have a one-on-one tutorial situation.

But the best 'teacher' of a three-year-old is often another child who is just a little bit older and has mastered a skill. This process is good for both the tutor and the younger child. In the Montessori approach, the teacher is not the primary focus.

Montessori encourages children to learn from each other. By having enough children in each age group, all students will find others at, above, and below their present level of development. This also makes Montessori schools economically more viable, allowing schools to attract teachers with far greater training and experience.

Some parents worry that by having younger children in the same class as older ones, one age group or the other will be

shortchanged. They fear that the younger children will demand more of the teachers' time and attention or that the importance of covering the kindergarten curriculum for the five-year-olds will prevent them from giving the three- and four-year-olds the emotional support and stimulation that they need. My experience has convinced me that both concerns are misguided and I can't imagine teaching in any other way.

There are several distinct advantages to the Montessori classroom model.

In a well run and established Montessori class, children are typically far more independent and self-disciplined. One factor that makes this possible is that each teacher's class of students doesn't leave at the end of the school year.

Children normally enter at age three and stay for a full three-year cycle, when they move on to the first year of the Montessori 6 - 9 year-old class. With two-thirds of the students returning each fall, the classroom culture is surprisingly stable.

Each child is a unique individual; no two are the same. Even with the smallest teacher-pupil ratios, each will have her own interests, abilities, strengths, and weaknesses. Each child learns at her

own pace and will be ready for any given lesson in her own time, not on the teacher's schedule of lessons.

Each child has her own learning style. Montessori teachers treat each child as an individual and customize lessons to fit her needs, personality, and interests.

Since Montessori allows children to progress through the curriculum at their own pace, there is no academic reason to group children according to one grade level.

In a mixed-class, children can always find peers who are working at their current level. Working in one class for two or three years allows students to develop a strong sense of community with their classmates and teachers. The age range also allows the especially gifted child the stimulation of intellectual peers, without requiring that she skip a grade and feel emotionally out of place.

To accommodate the needs of individual learners, Montessori classrooms have to include curriculum to cover the entire span of interests and abilities up through the oldest and most accelerated students in the class. This creates a highly enriched learning environment.

In multi-level classrooms, younger children are constantly stimulated by the interesting work in which the older ones are engaged.

At the same time, in multi-level classrooms, older students serve as tutors and role models for the younger ones, which helps them in their own mastery (we learn things best of all when we teach to someone else) and leaves them beaming with pride. 🌸



Got a young chef in your house? Check out this website:

kitchenkapers.com

There's a whole section of cooking products for kids!

Montessori Software for Ages 2½-12

Developed by Montessori Teachers for School or Home!

EXTREME SALE 63% OFF

Grammar Module 1 FREE (\$125 Value)

**FIRST time in 17 years for such extreme discounts.*

We have developed a wonderful series of **educational, interactive**, computer programs for children who are eager to learn! These revolutionary programs are exact and true to the **Montessori method** of education and designed to enhance the learning experience through independent, self-paced and fast motivating lessons. We offer several programs in a **variety of subjects** taught by an experienced Montessori teacher. Additionally, these programs are highly effective with children with learning differences such as **ADD, ADHD and Dyslexia**.

"First Time Ever!" SCHOOLS BUY for PARENT PRICES!"

Programs Feature:

Math
Reading
Spelling
Geography
Time
History
Zoology
Astronomy
Grammar



MECS

Montessori Educational Computer Systems

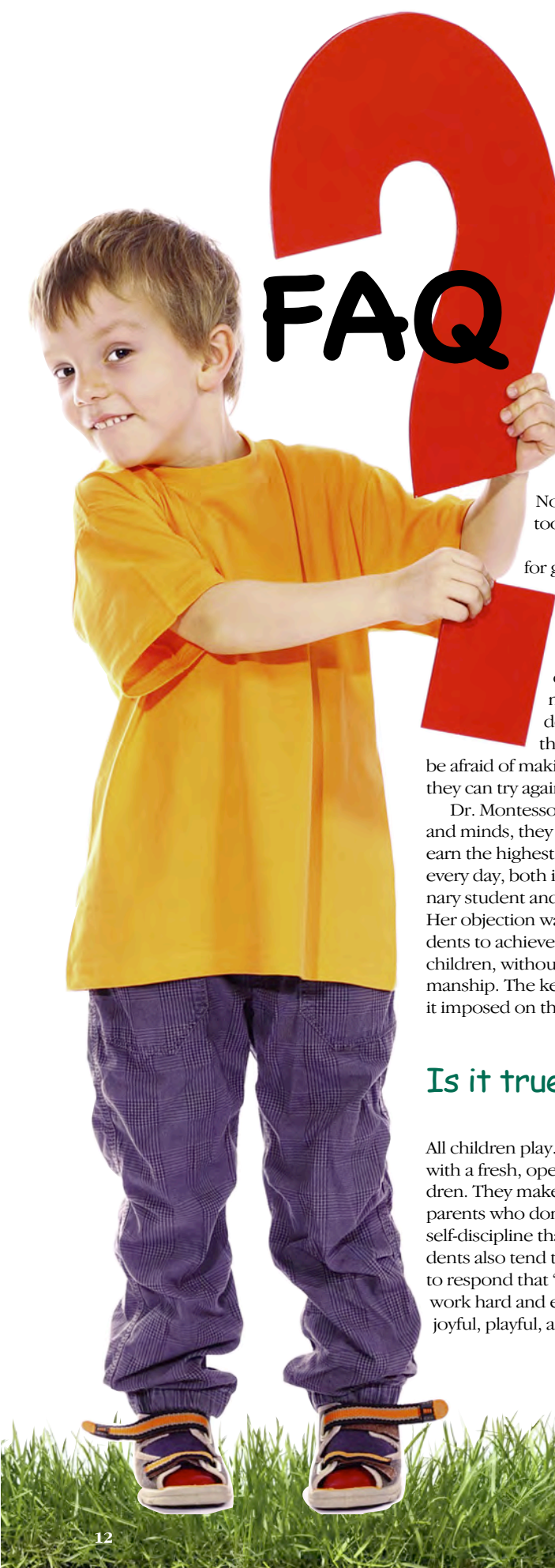
Phone/Fax: 512-686-5466

Orders: 877-238-5244

Visit: www.mecssoftware.com

E-mail: mecs@mecssoftware.com





FAQ

Isn't Montessori elitist?

Montessori is an educational philosophy and approach that can be found in all sorts of settings, from the most humble to large, well equipped campuses. In general, Montessori schools consciously strive to create and maintain a diverse student body, welcoming families of every ethnic background and religion, and using scholarships and financial aid to keep their school accessible to deserving families. Montessori is also found in the public sector as magnet public-school programs, Headstart centers, and as charter schools.

Is Montessori opposed to competition?

No. Dr. Montessori simply observed that competition is an ineffective tool to motivate children to learn and work hard in school.

Traditionally, schools challenge students to compete with each other for grades, class rankings, and special awards. For example, tests are graded on a curve developed from the performance of the students in that class. Students are constantly measured against their classmates, rather than considered for their individual progress.

In Montessori schools, students learn to collaborate with each other rather than mindlessly compete. Students discover their own innate abilities and develop a strong sense of independence, self-confidence, and self-discipline. In an atmosphere in which children learn at their own pace and compete only against themselves, they learn not to be afraid of making mistakes. They quickly find that few things in life come easily, and they can try again without fear of embarrassment.

Dr. Montessori argued that for an education to profoundly touch children's hearts and minds, they must learn because they are curious and interested, not simply to earn the highest grade in the class. Montessori children compete with each other every day, both in class and on the playground. Dr. Montessori, herself an extraordinary student and a very high achiever, was never opposed to competition in principle. Her objection was to using competition to create an artificial motivation to get students to achieve. Montessori schools allow competition to evolve naturally among children, without adult interference unless the children begin to show poor sportsmanship. The key is the children's voluntary decision to compete, rather than having it imposed on them by the school.

Is it true that Montessori children never play?

All children play. They explore new things playfully. They watch something of interest with a fresh, open mind. They enjoy the company of treasured adults and other children. They make up stories. They dream. They imagine. This impression stems from parents who don't know what to make of the incredible concentration, order, and self-discipline that we commonly see among Montessori children. Montessori students also tend to take the things they do in school seriously. It is common for them to respond that "this is my work," when adults ask what they are playing with. They work hard and expect their parents to treat them and their work with respect. But it is joyful, playful, and anything but drudgery.

Is Montessori opposed to fantasy and creativity?

You will not generally find play kitchens, dress-up corners, or dolls in a Montessori class for children under age six, because children are using real tools and doing real things, instead of pretending. However, imagination and creativity are important aspects of a Montessori child's experience.

Montessori classrooms incorporate art, music, dance, and creative drama throughout the curriculum. Imagination plays a central role as children explore how the natural world works, visualize other cultures and ancient civilizations, and search for creative solutions to real-life problems.

In Montessori schools, the arts are normally integrated into the rest of the curriculum. They are modes of exploring and expanding lessons that have been introduced in science, history, geography, language arts, and mathematics.

Art and music history and appreciation are woven throughout the history and geography curricula. Traditional folk arts are used to extend the curriculum as well. Students participate in music, dance, and creative movement with teachers and specialists. Students' dramatic productions make other times and cultures come alive.

What if a child doesn't feel like working?

While Montessori students are allowed considerable latitude to pursue topics that interest them, this freedom is not absolute. Within every society, there are cultural norms; expectations for what a student should know and be able to do by a certain age. Experienced Montessori teachers are conscious of these standards and provide as much structure and support as is necessary to ensure that students live up to them. If, for some reason, it appears that a child simply needs time and support until he or she is developmentally ready to catch up, Montessori teachers provide it non-judgmentally.

Is Montessori opposed to homework, tests, and grades?

Many parents have heard that Montessori schools do not believe in homework, grades, and tests. This is really a misunderstanding of Montessori's insights.

Homework

Most Montessori schools do not assign homework at all below the elementary level. When it is assigned to older children, it rarely involves page after page of busywork; instead, it involves meaningful, interesting assignments that expand on the topics that the children are pursuing in class. Many assignments invite parents and children to work together.

Homework should never become a battleground between adult and child. One of our goals as parents and teachers should be to help the children learn how to get organized, budget time, and follow through until the work is completed. Ideally, home challenges will give parents and children a pleasant opportunity to work together on projects that give both parent and child a sense of accomplishment. They are intended to enrich and extend the curriculum.

Homework doesn't need to be boring! Montessori challenges children to think, explore, and pursue tangible projects that give them a sense of satisfaction. Homework is intended to afford students the opportunity to practice and reinforce skills introduced in the classroom.

Moreover, there is a certain degree of self-discipline that can be developed within the growing child through the process of completing assignments independently.

Many elementary Montessori classes send home packets of *At-Home Challenges* for each age group in the class. The children have an entire week to complete them. When the week is over, teachers will normally sit down with the children to review what worked, what they enjoyed, and what they found difficult or unappealing.

Depending on the child's level, assignments usually involve some reading, research, writing, and something tangible to accomplish. They may be organized into three groups: 1) **Things to be experienced**, such as reading a book, visiting the museum, or going to see a play; 2) **Things to learn**, stated in terms of skills and knowledge, such as *See if you can learn how to solve these problems well enough that you can teach the skill to a younger student*; and 3) **Things to be submitted**, such as a play, essay, story, experiment, or model.

When possible, teachers will build in opportunities for children to choose among several alternative assignments. Sometimes, teachers will prepare individually negotiated weekly assignments with each student.

Tests

Montessori children usually don't think of our assessment techniques as tests so much as challenges. Early childhood Montessori teachers observe their children at work or ask them to teach a lesson to another child to confirm their knowledge and skill.

Most elementary Montessori teachers will give their students informal, individual oral exams or have the children demonstrate what they have learned by either teaching a lesson to another child or by giving a formal presentation. The children also take and prepare their own written tests to administer to their friends. Students are working toward mastery, rather than being graded using a standard letter grade scheme.

Standardized Tests

Very few Montessori schools test children younger than the first or second grade; however, most regularly give elementary students quizzes on the concepts and skills that they have been studying. Many schools ask their older students to take annual standardized tests.

While Montessori students tend to score very well, Montessori educators frequently argue that standardized testing is inaccurate, misleading, and stressful for children. The ultimate problem with standardized tests is that they have

often been misused, misunderstood, and misinterpreted in other schools. Tests can be fairly useful when seen as a simple feedback loop, giving both parents and school a general sense of how students are progressing.

Although standardized tests may not offer a terribly accurate measure of a child's basic skills and knowledge, in our culture, test-taking skills are just another practical life lesson that children need to master.

Reporting Student Progress

Because Montessori believes in individually paced academic progress, and encourages children to explore their interests rather than simply complete work assigned by their teachers, we don't assign grades or rank students within each class according to their achievement.

At the elementary level, students will often prepare a monthly self-evaluation of the previous month's school work. When completed, they will meet with the teachers, who will review it and add their comments and observations.

In many Montessori schools, children compile a collection of their work that is pulled together in a portfolio of the year's work.

Most schools schedule family conferences two or three times a year to review their children's portfolios and self-evaluations and go through the teachers' assessment of their children's progress.

Typically, once or twice a year, Montessori teachers will prepare a written narrative evaluation of the students' work, social development, and mastery of fundamental skills.

What about children with special needs?

Every child has areas of special gifts, a unique learning style, and some areas that can be considered challenges. Each child is unique. Montessori is designed to allow for differences. It allows students to learn at their own pace, and is quite flexible in adapting for different learning styles. In many cases, children with mild physical handicaps or learning disabilities may do very well in a Montessori classroom setting. On the other hand, some children do much better in smaller, more structured classrooms.

Each situation has to be carefully evaluated individually to ensure that the program can successfully meet a given child's needs and learning style.

Is Montessori right for my child?

Most Montessori educators would agree that Montessori is a good fit for most children — but it may not be the right match for their parents.

Everything depends on what your family believes to be true about your children and important in their education.

Do you believe that children should be treated with dignity and respect and be encouraged to be independent, self-confident, and self-disciplined?

Do you believe that the best way to discipline is by being consistent, modeling the correct behavior, and by consciously teaching children how to do things correctly?

Do you believe that education should be enchanting, intriguing, and delightful, rather than traditionally structured and highly competitive?

If so, Montessori may be right for you.

But aren't there some children who just won't do well in Montessori?

The answer is both *yes* and *no*. Montessori schools are often successful with children, who would challenge any school, including the highly distractible and impulsive ones, for whom parents typically have the most concern. The reason why should be obvious: Montessori is designed to be flexible, adapting the program to meet the needs of each given child. It also allows children to move about, socialize independently (rather than work as part of a group), and progress at their own pace.

This doesn't mean, though, that every class and every Montessori teacher can meet the needs of every child. This is especially true if a child is violent, destructive, or excessively disturbing of the peace and order of the classroom. Each decision has to be made on a case-by-case basis.

Why is there so much variation among Montessori schools?

Many people assume that all Montessori schools are essentially the same. In reality, Montessori schools can differ dramatically, in size, facilities, programs, and emotional climate. They share a common philosophy and basic approach, but there may be tremendous variation among schools that use the name *Montessori*. There are more than four thousand Montessori schools in North America, but every one is unique. Even within the same school, each class may look and feel quite different from the others, reflecting the interests and personalities of the teachers; however, certain characteristics will be found in all classes that are honestly following the Montessori approach.

Dr. Montessori was a brilliant student of child development, and the approach that has evolved out of her research has stood the test for more than one hundred years in Montessori schools around the world. **The Montessori approach has three great qualities: the model is replicable; it can be adapted successfully into all sorts of new situations; and it is sustainable.** (Montessori programs don't tend to self-destruct after a few years, as do many other educational reforms.) However, the only 'pure' Montessori educator was Dr. Maria Montessori herself. The rest of us interpret and filter her ideas through our personalities and experience. 🌱

Free Parenting Tips Online

Check out this website and sign up for free daily parenting tips and other fun stuff for families:
www.parenting.com



Finding Motivation the Montessori Way

Can we really motivate others? How can we find our own motivation? How does motivation work in a Montessori classroom?

by Maren Schmidt

Daniel Pink in his current bestseller, *DRIVE: The Surprising Truth About What Motivates Us* makes the point that motivation is an individual and internal process. Notice the little “i” in the book’s title. The little “i” signifies intrinsic motivation.

External rewards and punishments rarely motivate our behavior for the long term. Money, good grades, stickers and prizes get us to change our behavior for a while. Punitive measures in the long run create fear, rebellion, and worse. External rewards sometimes coincide with our internal motivation and create a perceived cause and effect that is perhaps not valid.

Edward Deci and Richard Ryan, psychologists at the University of Rochester, describe deep human needs in their work with “self-determination theory,” an overarching construct of human mo-

tivation and personality that focuses on how an individual’s behavior is self-motivated and self-determined.

Deci and Ryan describe three deep human needs: the need to be able to direct our own lives; the need to grow, learn, and create new ideas, experiences and objects; and the need to have a sense of purpose to make our lives and the lives of those around us better. These three psychological needs motivate each of us to initiate a task and seek out essential activities that create our psychological health and physical well being. Deci and Ryan refer to these as the need for competence, the need for autonomy, and the need for relatedness. Pink uses the terms *autonomy*, *mastery*, and *purpose*. These three words also form an easy-to-remember acronym: **AMP**.

Fundamental Needs.

The needs for autonomy, mastery and purpose are considered to be fundamental needs in self-determination theory. In our Montessori teacher-training, discussions on fundamental needs and human tendencies comprise part of our philosophy lectures and readings. The underlying idea is that human beings have behaviors that stem from innate needs and tendencies, much like a bird has the instincts to build a nest, a spider will spin a web, and cows will stampepe when frightened.

According to Montessori philosophy human beings have two types of fundamental needs – physical and spiritual. Psychological or social might be substituted here for the term spiritual. Physical needs include the following: air; food; light; movement; protection from

danger; sleep; sexual expression; shelter; touch; and water. Spiritual or psychological needs include the following: acceptance; appreciation; becoming; belonging; celebration; closeness; community; consideration; contribution; emotional safety; empathy; honesty; love; reassurance; respect; support; trust; understanding; warmth; movement; exercise; creativity; exploration; orientation; inspiration; laughter; fun; contemplation; silence; ability to choose dreams, goals and values; ability to create self-worth; ability to create meaning; ability to create an authentic person; and ability to create personal integrity, beauty, harmony, peace, repetition, precision and exactness.

Human beings have certain tendencies toward behavior. These include tendencies toward activity, becoming, belonging, exploration, orientation, order, communication, imagination, exactness, repetition and perfection. As you can see, human tendencies and fundamental needs have some overlap. Each of these fundamental needs and human tendencies relate to one or more of the needs of autonomy, mastery and purpose.

The idea of human behavior being driven by needs is not a new one in the

Montessori world of learning and teaching. It is one of the basic ideas Montessorians use to view and understand child development and behavior.

This knowledge of human tendencies and fundamental needs form some of the building blocks of Montessori prepared environments – special places designed to help children meet their needs and tendencies at whatever their stage of personal development.

Dr. Montessori saw that child development changed in approximately six-year phases or, as she referred to them, planes of development. Each plane of development has unique characteristics, with the individual trying to meet the needs and tendencies of that period of development.

The first plane begins at birth through approximately the age of six years; the second plane of development is from age six to twelve years; the third plane is from ages 12 to 18 years; and the fourth plane is from 18 to 24 years. Each plane is divided into two three-year sub-stages. Growth is more rapid in the first sub-stage. In the second sub-stage, growth is slower and more stable. Each sub-stage for the first three planes of development has a special prepared environment for a three-year, multi-age group of children.

In the first plane of development, from birth through six years, movement, language, the refinement of sensory perceptions, social relations and order are the lens through which a child's development can be understood.

As the first tooth is lost, the child begins to move into the second plane of development and we can observe the changes in the child's needs and tendencies toward certain behaviors. The freely chosen activities of the six to twelve-year-old are centered on moral reasoning, use of the imagination, group dynamics, getting out of the narrow circle of family and close friends, and using a developing sense of right and wrong.

The third plane of development is characterized by rapid physical growth, sexual maturation and boundless energy; developing abilities to abstract, conjecture, predict and create; a need to be with peers and accepted; a need to be individually mentored by adults who are not their parents; a need to understand *What am I good at?* and *What am I good for?*; strong and often harsh self-criticism; a need for meaningful work that contributes to adult communities; a need to express new interests,



by Maren Schmidt

Home Responsibilities



The Award Winning Column that Helps Adults Understand Kids

Prepared by the Counseling and Guidance Department, College of Education, University of Arizona. Reprinted with permission.

In today's changing society, children are challenged to become "working partners" with parents and teachers. Challenges such as this one can be met in many ways: mutual respect; sharing of opinions; acceptance of decisions; cooperative setting of goals, standards, or limitations; and permitting certain rights and privileges.

Assuming responsibilities can enhance the individual interpersonally and intrapersonally. As the child learns the benefits of order resulting from cooperation, he begins to view himself as a person who is capable of making a contribution to others. Growth in this area is best acquired developmentally, whereby the child becomes useful and needed at an early age, with the expectation of becoming more self-reliant and independent as time passes.

The adult's personal experiences and situation may lead him to find many ways in which a child can contribute. Sometimes parents and teachers, aware of the need for giving children responsibility, are stymied at knowing what to do and what to expect. The following is intended to meet this need.

This list, prepared by teachers and parents, is CUMULATIVE. As the child advances in age or grade he can continue to maintain past responsibilities as well as assuming new ones. The list, meant to suggest possibilities, is only a starting point subject to the situation and creativity of the adults. **Children may be able to accomplish tasks at ages above or below those suggested.**

In training for these responsibilities, it may be wiser to proceed gradually. First establish a relationship and then, through friendly discussions, the adult and the child together may determine the manner in which the child can become a contributing member.

Before assigning duties, it would be helpful to keep some of the following principles in mind:

1. Children have rights as well as responsibilities. If these rights are arbitrarily or impulsively withdrawn by the adult, the child may feel dominated or revengeful and will resist any efforts to elicit his cooperation.

thoughts, and emotions; the need to acquire flexible and inquiring habits of the mind; and the need to develop a personal vision.

The young adult in the fourth plane of development has a need to go out into the world and create his or her own experiences. The young adult takes on the challenge of deciding to start college, creating new experiences through relationships and travel, and beginning career and married life. At the end of the fourth plane of development, the true adult should emerge.

With these concepts of fundamental needs, human tendencies, and the four planes of development, Montessori prepared environments – consisting of people, tools, ideas and nature that are perfect places for children to meet their innate needs for autonomy, mastery and purpose.

Autonomy: The Need to Direct Our Own Lives

The four essential components necessary for autonomy to thrive, according to Deci and Ryan, are having decision-making authority about task, time, technique and team. We need the ability and assurance that we can choose what to do, when to do it, how to do it, and with whom to do it.

Authentic Montessori classrooms have these basic components:

1. Adults professionally trained in Montessori philosophy, methods and materials for the group they are teaching
2. Specially prepared environments based on three-year age groups
3. Children's free choice of activity within a three-hour protected work cycle.

Activities in our Montessori classrooms have been designed and refined over a hundred years all over the world with all types of children – rich, poor, gifted, challenged – using observation of the child involved in self-selected activities, while keeping the ideas of human tendencies, fundamental needs and planes of development in the forefront.

Task

Children in Montessori classroom environments are given the freedom to choose their tasks. Once a child has been shown how to get lesson materials off the shelf, and given a preliminary lesson on how to use and return

the lesson materials to order, the child is free to choose that task. In a matter of a few weeks upon entering a Montessori classroom a three-year-old has dozens of activities to select.

Time

Children in a Montessori environment are also given time. In the optimum situations children have a protected three-hour-work cycle in which to do their self-selected tasks. The children are allowed to do a particular task as long as they choose. When they are finished with the task, the children return the lesson materials to the designated place on the shelf and select the next task. This gift of choice, time, and task helps the children develop confidence in their choices and helps them develop concentration as well as independence – all aspects of autonomy.

Also, remaining in a classroom for a three- or four-year period contributes to this factor of time in the development of autonomy.

Technique

Another aspect of autonomy is having the ability to choose how you do a task.

2. Children should be consulted about the jobs that need to be done. After they have helped identify the work, then they must help set the standards for work, and be involved in the evaluation of the completed job.
3. Allow the children choices in which jobs they would like to do. (Not doing anything is not one of the choices). They must then follow through with their choice or experience the consequences.
4. Allow the consequences to follow logically from the uncompleted job. Do not discuss beforehand what will happen if someone does not fulfill the commitment.
5. Place appropriate time limits on when a task should be completed. If the child participated in setting these time limits, he will be more willing to meet them.
6. Vary the tasks to do. Children become easily bored with the same thing. They like the challenge of a new or unusual job.
7. Use common sense in the number of tasks expected of each child. He may stage a 'sit-down' strike if he feels used.
8. Remember you are a model of 'order' to your children. Do not expect an orderliness or cleanliness from them that you do not expect of yourself.
9. Examine your own standards. Perhaps you are a perfectionist about your house or classroom, feel uncomfortable if things are slightly out of order, or are concerned about what others will think. Learn to accept the house or classroom as a place of work and communication for the members, and not as a reflection of your own personal worth.
10. Never do anything for a child that he can do for himself.

Tasks for Two-Year-Olds

- Pick up toys and return to proper place.
- Put books and magazines in a rack.
- Sweep the floor.
- Place napkins and silverware on table.
- Clean up what they drop when eating.
- Give a choice of two foods for breakfast.
- Clear own place at the table.
- Toilet training.
- Brush teeth, wash hands, and brush hair.
- Undress self.
- Wipe up own spills.
- Put food away from grocery sacks to shelves.



continued →

Children in Montessori environments are allowed to find their own method of working with the materials. Each set of Montessori materials has a preliminary lesson, followed by other lessons as the Montessori guide (teacher) observes the child, requiring new challenges while working on his or her self-selected tasks.

The child is allowed to explore the limitations of the materials, as long as the material is not abused or used to harm others. For example, the Pink Tower is a set of ten cubes varying in dimension from one to ten centimeters. The preliminary lesson shows the child how to move the Pink Tower to a rug, build a tower with the largest cube on the bottom, then how to return the cubes to their place. As the child explores the limits of the Pink Tower over a three-year period in the early childhood environment, a variety of designs may be seen as the child chooses self-discovered techniques, not simply imitating a teacher's example. Every lesson, within the limits of safety, can be freely explored to allow the child this important development of technique.

Another aspect of technique is that the children have a variety of materials to explore different ideas. In the exploration of addition, the child can choose

from Red Rods, Golden Bead Materials, the Snake Game, the Stamp Game, Addition Strip Board, and the Small Bead Frame, to only mention a few of the math materials available to the child to promote autonomy using task, time and technique.

Team

The last of our four T's of autonomy is team, or the ability to choose with whom you will work. One interesting aspect of a Montessori environment is that children are allowed to politely decline a teacher's invitation to a lesson. "No, thank you. I'd rather choose to work on something else," is not an uncommon phrase. As you observe Montessori environments of all ages, you'll see a fluidity of small work groups. Five-year-old Max may do reading exercises with four-year-old Emily, then choose to work with six-year-old Jane and Tom to do some four-digit addition problems. Among the children, there is a quiet acknowledgement of acceptance or refusal to join others in self-selected tasks.

The children honor others' rights to choose their task, time, technique, and team. It is this deep respect of autonomy in our Montessori classrooms that

create the happy hum of children busy working, working toward another deep human need, mastery.

Mastery: The Need to Grow, Learn, and Create

As we learn and repeat new tasks, we need, what Pink refers to as, "Goldilocks' tasks" – tasks that are not too hot or not too cold, but just right. When there is a mismatch of what we can do and the next level of desired learning, we create a source of frustration. When we are given tasks that are too difficult, we become anxious or give up in resignation. If we are asked to do something too easy, boredom ensues, and behavior can range between passivity to creating chaos.

As we learn new skills, we want to be in the "zone of proximal development" (ZDP) to use a term from the psychologist Lev Vygotsky. We can think of learning tasks falling into three categories: the level where we know how to do something and find the work lacks challenge; the level of skill building where we don't have the necessary preparation to be successful; and the third (or middle) level, where we have the foundational skills and can move forward when



Tasks for Three- and Four-Year-Olds

- Setting the table, even with good dishes.
- Put the groceries away.
- Help with grocery shopping and grocery list.
- Polish shoes and clean up afterwards.
- Follow a schedule for feeding pets.

- Help do yard and garden work.
- Make the beds and vacuum.
- Help do the dishes and fill the dishwasher.
- Dust the furniture.
- Have goal chart with tasks.
- Spread butter on sandwiches.
- Prepare cold cereal.
- Help prepare plates of food for family dinner.
- Make a simple dessert (gelatin, ice cream, yogurt).
- Hold the hand mixer to whip potatoes or mix batter.
- Get the mail.
- Should be able to play without constant adult supervision.
- Fold laundry.
- Polish silver, brass, and a car.
- Sharpen pencils.



Tasks for Five-Year-Olds →

we are shown how to do a new set of tasks. The ZDP is where we find our Goldilocks' tasks of being "just right."

When the task given combines skill and interest, an interesting phenomenon occurs. The child yearns to learn. In the words of Dr. Montessori, "The role of education is to interest the child profoundly in an external activity to which he will bring all his potential."

In our Montessori prepared environments the child is surrounded with and introduced to various tasks that he or she may later choose. If the child meets an obstacle or requires fresh challenge, the watchful Montessori teacher is there to give a lesson that is "just right" for the individual's child's zone of proximal development.

The prepared environment of children and adults, lesson materials, underlying principles, and the outdoors, calls the child interests, while providing the appropriate tasks, time, techniques and team that lead the child to mastery.

A Montessori teaching technique that keeps children walking the tightrope between repetition and excitement is called "indirect preparation." For example, we know that reading and writing will be two essential skills students will want to master. Many of the tasks offered to the young

child three to six years old prepare the children indirectly and incrementally for the tasks of writing and reading. (Note: In Montessori teaching, we regard writing as indirect preparation for reading, but that is for another article for another day.)

A two-and-a-half to three-year-old enters the classroom and learns to wash a table using a counterclockwise circular motion, starting with the first stroke at the upper left-hand corner of the table. The child scrubs across the table to the right until he or she reaches the right-hand edge. The child then begins again on the left, under the first row of scrubbing, and continues thus until the entire top of the table is scrubbed. The three-year-old is happy making soap bubbles in a self-selected activity that nourishes the young child's natural tendencies to learn practical living skills. The child has no idea that this task is indirectly readying his hands and eyes for the job of writing (as it is done in western cultures – from left to right).

Writing and spelling emerge as self-selected tasks around the age of four-and-a-half years. With the indirect preparation of washing a table and other practical life jobs, as well as the indirect preparation of using the Sandpaper

Letters, the child desiring to write finds that he is in the Goldilocks chair.

The practical life tasks of the young child appear non-academic but serve as powerful preparation for the hand and eye to work together to ensure writing and reading success. The young child is offered many practical life skills that create coordination for later cognitive development and academic learning.

Three Laws of Mastery.

Pink refers to the three laws of mastery. Mastery is a mindset. Mastery is a pain. Mastery is an asymptote.

Mastery is a mindset. The idea of mastery becomes an attitude or expectation. "Good, better, best. Never let it rest. Until your good is better, and your better, best."

When we give our students in our Montessori classrooms autonomy to choose their tasks, times, technique and team, the idea of continual improvement is in the air. Children choose their work groups for a variety of reasons, but many times, it is because they know their co-workers are better than they are at a particular task and that working with them will help them get better. In a multi-age classroom, there is always some-

- Help with meal planning and grocery shopping.
- Make own sandwich and simple breakfast. Clean up.
- Pour own drink.
- Prepare dinner table.
- Tear up lettuce for salad.
- Measure and pour ingredients for a recipe.
- Make bed and clean room.
- Dress and choose outfit.
- Scrub sink, toilet, and bathtub.
- Clean mirrors and windows.
- Separate clothing for laundry.
- Answer and dial phone properly.
- Yard work.
- Pay for small purchases.
- Help clean out the car.
- Take out the garbage.
- Help make family entertainment decisions.
- Learn to tie shoes.
- Feed pets and clean the living area.



Tasks for Six-Year-Olds

- Choose clothing according to weather.
- Shake rugs.
- Water plants and flowers.
- Peel vegetables.
- Cook simple food (toast, hot dog, boiled eggs)
- Prepare own lunch for school.
- Hang up own clothes in closet.
- Gather wood for fireplace.
- Rake leaves and weed.
- Take pet for a walk.
- Tie own shoes.
- Responsible for minor injuries.
- Keep garbage container clean.
- Straighten and clean silverware drawer.

continued →

one who can do something better than you can. Plus, there is always someone to help. Mastery is part of the Montessori culture.

Mastery is a pain. Improvement requires focused effort, and that can be a pain. But when something is important, we are willing to work for it and to exert the effort to meet our objectives. Persevering with passion is a key ingredient to obtaining mastery. Mastery is not about innate talent but the ability to have focused practice for many years – over 10,000 hours of conscious practice in trying to improve. When we live in an environment where searching out and choosing challenging tasks is a habit, passionate perseverance helps us overcome the difficulty of becoming good, better, best. As we strive for our personal best, we come upon a paradox of mastery. As hard and long as we might try, we will never reach perfection. And that is okay.

Mastery is an asymptote. An asymptote is a line that approaches a curved line but never quite touches it, all the

way to infinity. Such is the paradox of mastery. We can never reach perfection, but it is that innate drive to be better that makes life fun and helps us have a sense of purpose.

Purpose: The Need to Have a Reason to Make Life Better

To be a help to life is the Montessori call to action. Montessori prepared environments are designed to meet the developmental needs and human tendencies for a particular age group of children. Montessori teaching techniques promote autonomy and mastery, creating powerful learning for children in a Montessori environment. Tapping into a sense of purpose, though, brings one's abilities to a higher level.

Beginning with young children learning to wash their hands, to button their coats, and to zip their pants, these practical life skills tap into a child's innate desires for independence and to be self-directed. Independence, as an innate purpose, has three-year-olds sweeping

floors, dusting, or cutting vegetables with a skill and care you might observe in children many years older.

The activities of making and serving snack for themselves and others feed into the children's sense of purpose. Practical life activities that involve caring for yourself, caring for others, and caring for the indoor and outdoors create a sense of purpose not only for the three- to six-year-old groups, but also with the elementary and adolescent communities.

Whereas young children are content with the purposeful activity within the confines of their classroom community, elementary-aged children's sense of purpose begins to be concerned with the larger world and this age's developing sense of morality and justice. The young child's purpose is found in sweeping the classroom floor. Perhaps, the elementary child's purpose is realized with sweeping the pavilion at the park as community work. For the adolescent, purposeful work may be sweeping the floor of an ill neighbor or family member.



Tasks for Seven-Year-Olds

- Oil and care for bike and lock it when unused.
- Take phone messages and write them down.
- Run small errands for parents.
- Sweep and wash patio area.
- Water the lawn.
- Properly care for bike and other outside equipment.
- Wash cat or dog.

- Train pets.
- Carry in the grocery sacks.
- Get self up in the morning and to bed at night on own.
- Learn to be polite, courteous, and to share; respect others.
- Be responsible for carrying own lunch money and notes back to school.
- Leave the bathroom in order. Hang up clean towels.
- Do simple ironing of flat pieces.
- Wash down walls and scrub floors.

Tasks for Eight- and Nine-Year-Olds

- Fold napkins properly and set silverware properly.
- Mop or buff the floor.
- Clean Venetian blinds.
- Help rearrange furniture. Help plan the layout.
- Run own bath water.
- Help others with their work when asked.
- Straighten out own closet and drawers.
- Shop for and select own clothing and shoes with parent.
- Change school clothes without being told.
- Fold blankets.
- Sew buttons.

- Sew rips in seams.
- Clean storage room.
- Clean up animal 'messes' in the yard and house.
- Begin to read recipes and cook for the family.
- Baby-sit for short periods of time as mother's helper.
- Cut flowers and make a centerpiece.
- Pick fruit off trees.
- Build a campfire, get items ready to cook.
- Paint fence or shelves.
- Help write simple letters.
- Help with defrosting and cleaning refrigerator.
- Feed the baby.
- Write thank-you notes.
- Polish silverware, copper, or brass items.
- Clean patio furniture.
- Wax living room furniture.

Tasks for Nine- and Ten-Year-Olds

- Change sheets on the bed and put dirty sheets in the hamper.
- Operate the washer and dryer.
- Measure detergent and bleach.
- Buy groceries with a list and comparative price shop.
- Cross streets unassisted.
- Keep track of own appointments.

Purpose makes us feel important and that the work we do for our family and community is vital. The five-year-old forgets to sweep the floor after lunch, and her friends will have to sit in crumbs. Forget to sweep the pavilion, the park looks trashy. Forget to go to the neighbors, and the young teen finds that his help is vital to the smooth running of someone else's life.

Purpose is found in our Montessori classrooms by the offering of self-selected challenging activities that passionately engage the intellectual, the physical, the emotional and the social aspects of our children.

Summary.

Support for the deep fundamental needs of autonomy, mastery, and purpose – the keys to intrinsic motivation, and a lifetime of well being – are found in our Montessori classrooms for all ages of children. Montessori teaching and learning techniques, that include an understanding of fundamental human

needs, human tendencies, and a continuum of child development form the basis of the special Montessori prepared environments for each three year sub-stage of child development.

To be a help to life we need to observe, nourish, protect and strengthen our children by tapping into the powerful intrinsic motivation that exists from birth. It shouldn't surprise us that our Montessori schools are uniquely positioned to help our children gain autonomy, mastery, and purpose for a life well lived. 🌿

REFERENCES:

Deci, E. L., & Ryan, R. M. *Intrinsic Motivation and Self-Determination in Human Behavior*. (Plenum Press) New York: 1985

Deci, E. L., & Ryan, R.M. *Handbook of Self-Determination Research* (University of Rochester Press) Rochester, NY: 2002

Pink, Daniel H. *DRIVE: The Surprising Truth About What Motivates Us* (Riverhead Books) New York: 2009

Montessori, Maria. *From Childhood to Adolescence* (ABC –Clio Ltd.) Oxford, England: 1948, 1994

Montessori, Mario. *The Human Tendencies and Montessori Education* (Association Montessori Internationale, Second Edition) Amsterdam: 1956

Schmidt, Maren. *Understanding Montessori: A Guide for Parents* (Dogear Publishing) Indianapolis, Indiana: 2009

Vygotsky, L. S. *Mind in Society: Development of Higher Psychological Processes* (Scribner) New York, 1978



Maren Stark Schmidt, an award-winning teacher and writer, founded a Montessori school, and holds a Masters of Education from Loyola College in Maryland. She has over twenty-five years experience working with young children and holds teaching credentials from the Association Montessori Internationale. She currently writes a syndicated parenting column, available at www.KidsTalkNews.com and recently completed a book, Understanding Montessori: A Guide For Parents. Contact her at Maren@KidsTalkNews.com. Copyright 2009.

- Prepare deserts from box mixes.
- Prepare a family meal.
- Receive and answer own mail.
- Pour and make tea, coffee, and juice.
- Wait on guests.
- Plan own birthday and other parties.
- Learn simple first aid use.
- Do neighborhood chores.
- Sew, knit, weave (even using a sewing machine).
- Do chores without a reminder.
- Learn banking and how to be thrifty and trustworthy.
- Wash the family car.

Tasks for Ten- and Eleven-Year-Olds

- Earn own money (baby-sit, yard work).
- Be home alone.
- Use public transportation.
- Know proper conduct when staying overnight with a friend.
- Pack own suitcase.
- Be responsible for personal hobby.
- Handle self properly when in public places alone or with peers (movies, etc.).

Tasks for Eleven- and Twelve-Year-Olds

- Join outside organizations, do assignments, and attend meetings.
- Take responsibility as a leader.
- Put siblings to bed and dress them.
- Clean pool and pool area.
- Respect other's property.
- Run own errands.
- Mow the lawn.
- Help build things and do the family errands.
- Clean oven and stove.
- Schedule ample time for studies.
- Buy own sweets or treats.
- Be responsible for paper route.
- Check and add oil to car or lawn mower.

Tasks for Junior High Students

- Determine how late to stay up during the week.
- Determine how late to be out for evening gatherings through mutual parent-child discussion and agreement.
- Take complete responsibility for preparing family meals.

- Develop social awareness: good health, exercise, necessary rest, correct weight, nutritious food, physical examinations.
- Anticipate the needs of others and initiate the appropriate action.
- Have realistic acceptance of capabilities and limitations.
- Understand self-respect or individual worth.
- Be responsible for one's decisions.
- Demonstrate mutual respect, loyalty and honesty in the family.

xxx

I've used this list for almost twenty-five years after receiving it at a parent education meeting.



Ecoliteracy:

Getting to Know the Natural World on a First-Name Basis

by Leigh Ann Carver
Mountaintop Montessori
Charlottesville, VA

“There is no description, no image in any book that is capable of replacing the sight of real trees and all of the life to be found around them in a real forest. How often is the soul of man—especially in childhood—deprived because he is not allowed to come in contact with nature.”

— Maria Montessori

Montessori schools have made a conscious effort to take their students outside, from the earliest days when an inner-city courtyard was the best that could be done, to get some fresh air and sunlight. As Montessori education spread to suburban and rural locations, greater use of the outdoors became possible, and students at many contemporary Montessori schools observe wildlife, engage in hands-on life-science lessons, or raise vegetables on campus.

Mountaintop Montessori in Charlottesville, Virginia has offered a number of ways for students to work outdoors over the years and has recently seen programs from various phases in the school's history come together to create exponentially greater opportunities for students to grow in their knowledge of, and connection to, the natural world.



As is so often the case, Mountaintop's early environmental education projects flowed from faculty members' willingness to share their areas of expertise with the students. Estra Roell, who guided lower elementary students for twenty years at the school, came to share a weekend interest in birdwatching with Alma Scheible, who was her classroom assistant at the time. They installed the first birdfeeder on our campus just outside their classroom's windows. Soon, they discovered that watching birds made for a wonderfully concrete way for

students to learn about how animals adapt in their environments and why the health of those environments is crucial to the animals' survival. Having learned to identify types of beaks and feet, students understand how birds meet their needs for food and shelter and how local populations of shrubs, trees, insects, worms, and birds are all interrelated. Mountaintop embarked on its first environmental education project in partnership with Audubon International in 1999 and achieved certification through their program for schools in

2001. In 2002, Estra published an article in *Tomorrow's Child* on the benefits that working with Audubon had brought to our students, stating, "We have achieved many of the goals we established at the beginning of our involvement in the program, but our progress doesn't stop with certification as a Cooperative Sanctuary. We see our stewardship as a permanent, ongoing project and hope to maintain our relationship with Audubon International well into the future."

Over time, we've seen more and more evidence that the real, meaningful work of maintaining and expanding our sanctuary gives students the kinds of experiences they need to have early in life to build not only appreciation and knowledge of the natural world but also an understanding of their role in it and commitment to being lifelong, active stewards of it. Biennial recertification with Audubon gives adults on campus an opportunity to reflect on this. Our most recent recertification took place in the spring of 2010, and in it we reported on some exciting developments and considered how they related back to the essential theme of educating students to become ecoliterate citizens of their local and global communities.

Cornerstones of a Montessori Approach to Ecoliteracy

Montessori's Keen Understanding of Human Development

Dr. Maria Montessori, trained as a physician, used her scientific background to develop an innovative approach to understanding child development. This approach divides the child's life into four six-year stages, which together span birth to age twenty-four. Within each stage, the first three years are a time of great change and growth for the child, followed by consolidation during the second three years. Through the first three stages, adults support the child's development by observing, determining what support is needed, and giving appropriate guidance and challenge. The fourth stage constitutes young adulthood. Since Mountaintop serves 200 students, including toddlers, preschool/ kindergarten-aged children, elementary students, and adolescents, we see each of Dr. Montessori's planes of development every day. Over time, our students develop a kinship with the natural world by building on early sensorial experiences, moving into productive work in

the outdoors, and ending with the ability to make decisions and take action with optimism and confidence founded on those early successes.

1st plane | Toddler & Children's House | Ages 0 to 6 | Preschool & Kindergarten

From birth to age six, children are soaking everything in, constructing an understanding of the world through their senses. So, the 1st plane of development is called the "absorbent mind" phase. During this phase, children develop all the essential skills necessary for survival: to eat, to move, and to communicate. They are driven to refine those skills to meet their needs independently. The Toddler and Children's House ages are the most critical periods for bonding with the world and developing what entomologist E.O. Wilson calls "biophilia" – an affinity for the living world. During these formative years, our main objective is to cultivate empathy between the child and nature through direct experiences with plants and animals and complementary stories, songs, and seasonal celebrations.

2nd plane | Elementary | ages 6 to 12 | grades 1 to 6

From six to 12 years, children are hard at work making sense of the world around them. In this 2nd plane, we say they have a "reasoning mind." They are making connections, discovering reasons and starting to become familiar with the essentials of human knowledge. Elementary children are natural explorers, inclined to collect specimens; explore the woods and streams; observe amphibians, insects, and birds; hike trails; plant gardens; compost and recycle; tend animals; and, ultimately, make the connection that human beings need to live in harmony with the earth. Upon experiencing the living and non-living forces of nature, they easily draw the conclusion that all things, natural and man-made, are interdependent.

3rd plane | Middle School | ages 12 to 15 | grades 7 to 9

The complicated years of 12 to 18 are a time of physical growth, intense emotions, and refinement of beliefs and values. During these years, young people seek both independence and community. Adolescents practice the skills they need to participate in society and make

themselves ready to contribute to the wider world as individual adults. As Montessori children enter adolescence, their personal relationship with nature becomes a catalyst for social action on behalf of the environment. This devotion to the world around them provides context for studying the challenges facing our world today. These young adults emerge from their Montessori years understanding the unique relationship between human technology and nature's gifts. The Mountaintop student feels empowered to make positive and purposeful contributions to local and global environmental efforts out of genuine understanding and experience.

Our whole curriculum is organized to serve these planes of development, with children working in mixed-age groups but sharing the same characteristics and needs. Planting an area outside their classroom with carefully chosen shrubs and flowers and seeing them attract the insects and birds found in our area is one long-standing example of ecoliteracy lessons attuned to the children's development at our school. Other examples are found in programs we have developed more recently at Mountaintop.

An Organic Approach to Prepared Environments:

Spaces where children engage in outdoor work are prepared as carefully as the Montessori classrooms. These spaces should be suited to the needs of the children who will use them and should promote the students' growing independence. Our goal is that outdoor learning spaces be simple, beautiful, and orderly. There are a number of challenges faced in achieving this. Time is needed for plants to mature. Many hands of all sizes are needed to care for living, growing, outdoor learning spaces.



Financial hurdles to achieving prepared environments for teaching ecoliteracy can be substantial as well, but a new garden or greenhouse for student use is an attractive project for fundraising, and even a modest grant can be leveraged into huge progress for a school that has other essential elements in place.



Mountaintop's recent addition of an 850 square foot geodesic dome greenhouse is an example of how much can be done with minimal school resources.

In 2005, we launched a cooking program as a way to extend the wildly pop-

ular food preparation exercises of the children's house practical life curriculum into the elementary years. Students began taking turns working in the kitchen with an adult and their classmates in each of our elementary classrooms and were thrilled to have a homemade meal one day each week.

This program was extended to our middle school classroom in 2008, which set the stage for a big leap forward for the cooking program and its relationship to our efforts to teach ecoliteracy. With our growing middle school program in mind, the school had sought, and been awarded, grant funding for the significant infrastructure needed for ecoliteracy programs. When it came time to bring the new infrastructure to life, the middle school students, true to form, surprised the adults with some wonderful

but unexpected particulars. That year, some students in the class delved into the planning and creation of meals they were proud to share with classmates and invited adult guests, while others clearly thrived on researching and plan-

ning for the addition of a greenhouse to our campus. At the time our middle school class included only seventh and eighth graders, and two students who were in their final year of the program convinced the middle school guide and administration of the wisdom of adding a ninth-grade year to the program so that they could stay on to see the project through to completion! The grant funds were used to purchase a cleverly designed kit from Growing Domes. A parent who is a contractor served as the job foreman, preparing the site and supervising the many parents and students who donated their time to put it together.

When the greenhouse was opened at the start of the 2009-2010 school year, students, parents, and staff were excited to see it begin to fill with living things. The first plants grew vigorously in the growing conditions it provided, but no one was fully prepared for just how profound an impact this new feature would have on our program. The students' enthusiasm for cooking skyrocketed with the opportunity to plan meals made from the produce growing in the greenhouse. The success of this garden-to-table program quickly propelled action on several related fronts. The local United Way's annual Day of Caring brought fresh volunteer troops to campus to construct the 2300-gallon water tank that would provide the greenhouse's thermal mass over the winter. In subsequent months, middle school science lessons gave students an opportunity to learn the chemistry, and botany and zoology they needed to successfully populate the tank with a harmonious balance of plants, fish, and decomposer species in the spring. Plans for a new, extensive garden space adjacent to the greenhouse evolved rapidly, along with a revamping of our summer program to focus on gardening and cooking. In its first year, Mountaintop's Summer of Ecological Experience and Discovery, known as SEED, has begun to spread ecoliteracy to families and schools across our community by sharing our own students' successes in these areas with many more students, whose schools are not able to provide such experiences for them during the school year.

Achieving a Full Complement of Materials:

High-quality learning materials are essential to students' experiences out-

A catalog of child-size tools, games, and resources for the Montessori home

Cooking • Cleaning Up • Gardening
Sewing • Woodworking • Art • Music
Cooperative Games • Science & Nature
Peace Education • Parent Resources

for
smallhands
A RESOURCE FOR FAMILIES
Presented by Montessori Services

Earn Free Materials for Your School*
When You Order September 1 - December 31

888-513-3998
ForSmallHands.com

*some restrictions apply

doors just as they are in the classroom. In a Montessori school serving a broad range of ages, this means having plenty of sturdy garden tools in a variety of sizes, and field guides and other resources for students at different levels. Again, donations from foundations, individuals, and businesses that see ecoliteracy as an important topic in education have been critical to our success. Seed companies, local garden centers and market gardeners, and university-level agricultural research stations have donated supplies. Education grants from Virginia's Department of Environmental Quality have been obtained, and working with the local 4-H chapter on particular projects has helped as well. Small expenditures for student-made bee boxes, rain barrels, and worm composting bins are far outweighed by the value of the practical life and science lessons gained in building them.

Masterful Adult Guidance:

The guidance offered by experienced, trained adults is as important to students' work in the outdoors as it is in the classroom. Alma Scheible, the longest serving member of our faculty has been involved with a host of ecoliteracy efforts in her 24

years at Mountaintop. Over time, her role has grown from sharing her own passion for birdwatching with staff members and students in one classroom of first, second, and third graders to serving as a resource for the entire student and staff population. In recent years, most of Alma's time has been allocated to guiding groups of students of all ages, who not only maintain our bird sanctuary's many feeders, nesting boxes, and water features, but grow food, plan, budget, and prepare meals for their entire class. Experience has taught Alma how much the students are able to do for themselves and for each other. Her guidance always leaves room for them to make important discoveries on their own. Professional development for classroom faculty and for those who specialize in teaching ecoliteracy has been obtained through a local permaculture organization as well as through organizations such as the Natural Learning Initiative and Vermont Wilderness School.

Schedules Designed for Flow:

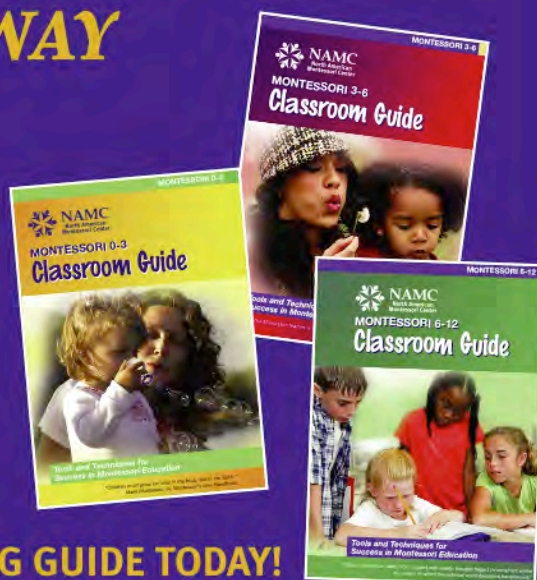
This is arguably where a Montessori school's ecoliteracy learning opportunities are most markedly different from the

school-yard gardening and other ecoliteracy efforts underway at numerous public schools and traditional independent schools around the country. The schedules in a Montessori learning community include long blocks of uninterrupted work time, during which students are exercising freedom with responsibility: making choices; working with peers; engaging in lessons with guides; and experiencing concentration and flow. Weeding the vegetable garden or maintaining shrubs in one of the bird gardens presents numerous opportunities for discovering mysteries that beg to be solved: nibbled (or gobbled) vegetation; animal tracks or scat; a nest with eggs in it; or a colony of insects. When



GUIDING YOUR CLASSROOM THE MONTESSORI WAY

- ✓ Normalization
- ✓ Classroom management
- ✓ Presentations & activities
- ✓ Classroom design & setup
- ✓ Starting the year right to maximize success
- ✓ Establishing rules and routines
- ✓ Guiding
- ✓ Modeling
- ✓ Observing
- ✓ Recordkeeping



ORDER YOUR MONTESSORI TEACHING GUIDE TODAY!



FOR DETAILS ON DIPLOMA PROGRAMS,
INDIVIDUAL SALES OF ALBUMS, DVD'S, AND BLACKLINE MASTERS:
www.montessoritraining.net Toll Free: 1-877-531-6665

these moments arise, students at Mountaintop are able to head to the ecology resource room to gather information from specimens and field guides. They compare their observations of the mystery item to pictures, descriptions, geographic data, and other relevant information. They narrow down the possibilities. They make more observations of the scene and so on until they discover the answer. If they've discovered a garden pest, they can determine what action they need to take to minimize the damage. On other occasions, they can just satisfy their curiosity about an interesting find. Either way, they've experienced a valuable process.

This often happens at Mountaintop, because the students' schedules are designed to be flexible and to encourage them to see things through from beginning to end. The confidence and in-depth knowledge they gain from these experiences are critical to our goal of empowering them to face the environmental challenges of the future. A traditional educational setting is typically focused on very near-term goals, such as the need to cover specific content that is required for students to move on to the next level and uses a more rigid schedule to ensure timely progress toward

those goals. We, too, have a curriculum to cover but prefer to take a longer view of when topics are learned to allow for individual student interests and the inevitable magic that happens along the way if you let it.

The Big Picture

With commitment and sustained effort, over time, all of these factors have combined to enable us to provide a steady diet of tangible experiences that foster students' attachment to the world around them. Through their work in the garden, greenhouse, and kitchen, students at Mountaintop become confident, determined, ecoliterate leaders, rather than fretful recipients of dire but abstract messages about far-off endangered animals and shrinking habitats or the suspect origins and poor quality of food available to so many in our communities.

Adult efforts are focused on creating a natural laboratory on our 10-acre campus and supporting the students' exploration of a rich variety of green, inviting, safe spaces to encourage curiosity, observation, critical thinking, and intellectual growth. Knowing that, without due care, even well intentioned environmen-

tal education can leave children feeling hopeless and distanced from the vibrant ecosystems and flora and fauna right outside their back doors, we are steadfast in offering real experiences in nature that give them a sense of their own power to have a positive effect on the future. 🌱

RESOURCES:

www.auduboninternational.org

Contact Audubon International through their website to learn more about their partnership programs. In addition to the program for schools, Audubon offers programs designed to help businesses, golf courses, hotels and resorts, neighborhoods and municipalities conserve resources and support wildlife.

www.ecoliteracy.org

The Center for Ecoliteracy's Resources page lists a number of helpful publications. At Mountaintop, we found that *Big Ideas: Linking Food, Culture, Health, and the Environment*, helped us to articulate the natural synergy between our students' practical life lessons in cooking and their lessons in disciplines such as botany, geography, history, and economics.

www.naturalearning.org

The Natural Learning Initiative, led by Robin Moore at NC State, offers design services and conducts research and offers workshops on the importance of unstructured time spent in natural spaces to the healthy development of children.

www.growingspaces.com

Learn more about the geodesic dome as an efficient structure for housing a beautiful, productive outdoor learning space. The greenhouse at Mountaintop was purchased from this provider.

Leigh Ann Carver is the Communications Director at Mountaintop Montessori. She enrolled her children here ten years ago and shared her experience in business and law as a trustee at the school prior to joining the school's administration in 2005. Leigh Ann and her husband, Andrew, are currently the parents of two Mountaintop students and a Mountaintop alumnus.



Early Childhood Teacher Certification (Ages 2^{1/2} to 6)

Upon successful completion of this program, students will be certified Montessori teachers. In addition, the program also fulfills half the graduate courses required for a Master's Degree in Education with specialization in Montessori Studies available through Goucher College in Towson, MD.

Alisa Anania, Program Director

Please direct all inquiries to:
Alison Bourdelais, Program Coordinator
Maryland Center for Montessori Studies
10807 Tony Drive, Lutherville, MD 21093
www.montessorischool.net

Year I:
(Starts September or January)
Evening Academic Phase

Year II:
Internship Year

- Beautiful learning environment in Greenspring Valley, near Baltimore
- Qualified, dedicated instructors
- Comprehensive Montessori curriculum
- Results in the prestigious certification of the American Montessori Society

For more information,
call (410) 321-8555

Certified by the State of Maryland, affiliated with the American Montessori Society and accredited by MACTE Commission.



**"How wonderful it is
that nobody need wait a
single moment before
starting to improve
the world."**

□ — *Anne Frank*



Why Screen Children Entering Montessori Schools?

There are many ways that we can get to know more about the children who apply to our schools before they are admitted, but why and how do we do that?

Lorna McGrath

**Director of the Family Education Center,
The Montessori Foundation**

If we are so open to children as individuals who progress at their own pace, why then would we spend time looking at them with some kind of standardized screening tool? Why wouldn't we just take each child as they are and assess them once they are in the school using the classroom materials?

All valid questions. Let's start with the *why*. Having been an admissions director for many years, I have come to know that it is important to find the right match for both the child and the school. A good screening tool can be a very useful part of that process. We know that we can accommodate most children in our schools because of the multi-sensory, hands-on approach to learning and a deep respect for each child's potential. However, there is a small percentage of children who may benefit from a smaller group size and a more adult-directed environment because of specific, and usually severe, exceptionalities. These children are usually relatively easy to spot. Having said that, the larger percentage of children that we can serve very well still may need some extra support along the way, which the teachers

observe and makes adjustments to according to their observations, experience, and creativity.

All right, so why use a screening tool of some sort during the admissions process? In part, we use screening tools because they can give the school a base line picture of the very young child. This base-line gives us a marker to compare the child's growth and development at a later time. This can be important in future years if there is a question about the child's growth: Is he progressing, staying at the same level, or falling behind? During the early childhood years, the classroom teachers are often the first ones to become aware of exceptionalities in young children. We know that early intervention is an important factor in supporting children's successful development. The screening results give credibility to the teacher's observations when discussing concerns with parents or other specialists.

Beyond that, during a developmental screening, the person administering it has a chance to interact with the child. The screener often gets a sense of the child's learning style, personality type, emotional maturity, and ability to interact with adults other than family members. All these factors weigh into whether the school is the best choice to meet the child's needs. Admission would certainly not be based on screening results alone. They would, however, give the parents and the admissions committee another piece of information to look at.

So, schools often choose to administer screenings to:

- Create a base line for comparison to future development
- Support teacher observations as the child develops
- See how a child interacts with adults other than family

- Get a sense of the child's likelihood of success in school.

The How of Screenings: As the adult works with the child, the adult is in the role of *screener* not teacher. At first glance, this might seem as if the adult is somehow trying to trip up the child with a trick question. For example: I was working with a family and administering a screening in their home. One of the parents happened to walk by when I asked the child, "Can you think of a word that rhymes with hat?" The child thought for a moment and said, "h." The next question was, "Can you think of a word that rhymes with ball?" Once again the child thought and answered by giving me the sound "b." The parent passing by said to me, "She doesn't know what *rhyme* means." Exactly, right!

This parent and I talked later about why I didn't explain or give a clue as to what *rhyme* meant. If I had done that, I would have put myself into the role of teacher rather than screener. My job as the screener is simply to find out what a child knows and what she doesn't know. Since the screening tool that I use can be administered to a range of ages, it is scored differently for a three-year-old than it is for a four-, five-, or six-year-old. There are some questions or activities in each of the three domains (cognitive, language, and motor) that we know a three-year-old would typically not answer correctly but that a six-year-old would. Because of the scoring, the three-year-old is not penalized for answering those questions incorrectly.

When working with children younger than three years old, the child's parents, with the guidance of a screener, often give or participate in giving screenings. Two advantages to this method of screening are:

- The child feels more comfortable and is more likely to do well; and
- The parents are able to see first hand how the child does.

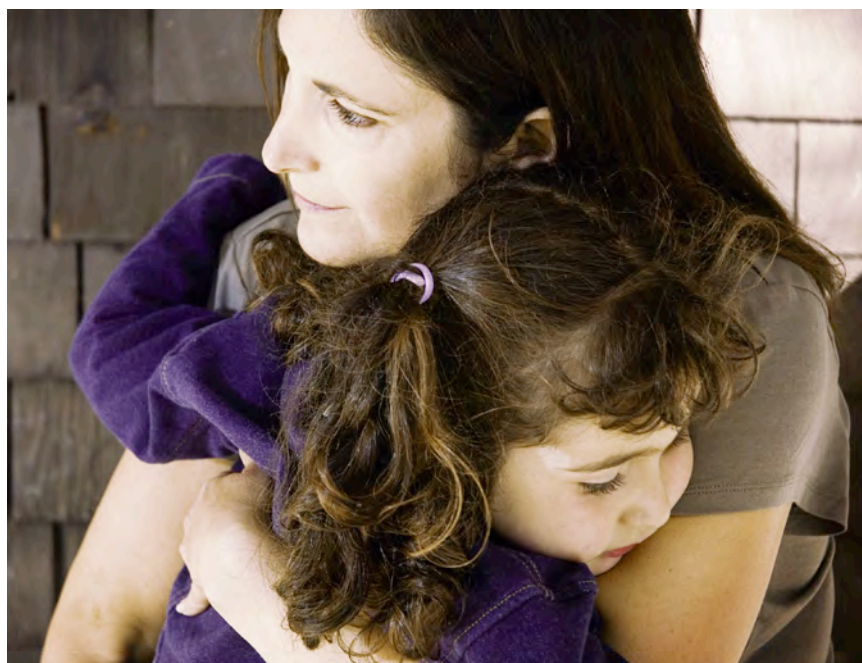
With elementary and older children, schools often do a variety of activities while new applicants are visiting in the classroom. Examples might include: a writing sample; some math work; possibly some of the map work; an interview with the admissions director or some adult other than the classroom teacher; or even an abbreviated standardized test. As children get older, they also usually have records from previous schools and possibly outside support persons, such as occupational therapists.

We screen children by interviewing, using standardized screening tools, inviting them in for a classroom visit, etc. During the admissions process our ultimate goal is always to find the best way to support the children and families that we admit to our schools.✎

Separation Anxiety



by Chelsea Howe,
MS, LGPC,
CAC-AD-trainee,
PsyD Candidate,
Montessori
Foundation Staff
Member



It's the beginning of the school year in North America, after many months of unstructured or semi-structured summer activity. Undoubtedly, things will be shaken in your child's world when they return to school this fall – perhaps, your world will be shaken, too!

Many children wait all year long for summer to hit, and who can blame them? They think about the pool, perhaps summer camp activities, seeing friends, taking family vacations, and so much more! But, the truth is, often summer seems to drag on at times and we all wish (even children) for the structured days to return.

For many children, even returning students, going back to school can be very difficult. Their idea of structure has taken on a whole new meaning over the last several months. Even for adults, it's easy to get into a more lenient swing of things – late-night play-dates at the pool often carry over to sleeping in, ever so slightly the next morning. And, the truth is, sometimes even employers become a little more lax during the summer months. So, it only seems normal that children (and adults) might have reservations about getting back to routine.

There are things, however, that can be done that will make this transition easier, on everyone. (As a side note, this article can also be applied to coming back from Thanksgiving, winter, and spring breaks).

First and foremost, begin implementing a routine, sooner rather than later. Even if it is a more lenient routine than you will ultimately follow during the school year, at least it is a routine. Parents, invite children to take part in reading before bedtime (or some other ritual – singing a lullaby, drawing a picture, etc.). Allow them to form their own little ritual around this activity, whether it's reading with a flashlight in a tented area

over the bed, or a nighttime snack while reading. Parents, form your own routine, too! Let that storytime be a time for you to begin relaxing ... think of it as Phase I. While your child is reading a book, drink some hot (decaffeinated) tea and visualize the story that is being told.

Make sure to begin waking up earlier and transition into this slowly. No one needs to go from eight hours of sleep to five hours of sleep with no transition. That's enough to cause anyone to have a meltdown.

Allow the routine to follow into morning rituals, too. This is a time for all of you to enjoy being together. For example, everyone can participate in making and serving breakfast. It not only helps provide a routine, but it is also an act of appreciation and allows for a feeling of connection, even in the morning when we may feel rushed, and many of us are not fully functioning yet.

If your school has this event, make sure to attend the orientation or back-to-school night prior to starting school. Many parents choose to skip this or may have vacations planned during that time period. Try to synchronize your schedule with school as best as possible. This is an important event for young children, even if they seem to protest at the thought of attending. These orientations help children rekindle and make new friendships and take the unknown and make it familiar.

When it comes to getting children off to school, it is so important for parents to support each other and to decide what will happen *before* it happens. With luck, children will show great enthusiasm on the first day, will jump out of bed, and will go forth without much reinforcement from parents. However, more often than not, there may be some reluctance, particularly in the first few days of school. Parents should determine how they want to handle the situation before

it happens.

The first day of school is exciting for all children, but for some children it is more stressful than exciting. Parents know their children better than anyone else and may suspect that their children will have difficulty being dropped off at school and being away from home. Warning signs may include: prior incidents of difficulty when separation occurs; evidence of shyness; stressors (e.g. medical difficulties, parental discord, etc); or prolonged attachment (e.g. never having been left with a baby sitter or relative, no play dates at other children's houses, etc.). To some extent, being ready to detach can be very difficult, not only for youngsters, but for parents, too.

If you suspect that your child may have difficulty with separating, it may be helpful to talk to the teacher ahead of time to give her the "heads up." Teachers and parents can work together to help the child adjust. If it is truly difficult, it may be helpful for your child to bring a "transitional object," something that he holds close to him to remind him that he is safe and make him feel comfortable (e.g. a friendship bracelet). If this is something that you feel might help, make sure you talk to the teacher first, so as not to cause any distractions to the rest of the class.

Parents should talk to their children before the first day to walk them through the steps. Even older children may be confused by the process (*Where does the bus stop, where will they be dropped off, and, most important, where will they be picked up?*). Children do best when certainty and routines are in place. Children who are overly fearful may require a little extra certainty. Allow them to ask questions and answer them to the best of your ability.

Finally, the day arrives (and many days after) that can cause parents heartache: the

actual separation. Many parents will arrive at school with their children and believe that everything is going according to plan – no meltdowns – happy child, happy parent. When they arrive at the classroom, however, things go terribly awry. This is where advance planning is essential.

Understandably, parents want to nurture their children, comfort them, and do whatever possible to help them in the process. However, this often has poor consequences when it is done improperly during the drop-off process. It usually results in just a temporary solution and may actually reinforce in the child the feeling that the classroom is a scary place.

Instead of lifting up the child and allowing her to latch onto your neck and wrap her legs around your waist, comfort her by crouching down to her level, sharing how brave she is to try something new, and leading her in the direction of the teacher (who can guide her to other children who are already happy with an ongoing activity). Share with her that you love her and can't wait to hear about her day at home when they will make macaroni and cheese together (or whatever is on tonight's menu; the point is to be concrete, because children think literally at certain ages).

Don't make promises, such as, "I promise you will have a great day." Don't do or say anything to make them feel any more vulnerable, such as, "You can call me whenever you want throughout the day if it's too hard." Do not sit in your car in the parking lot waiting for a call from the school. Do not hide in bushes to see if you can get a glimpse your child through the classroom window – just to make sure she's settled in. Montessori teachers are trained and will know if they need to call. Children watch their parents for cues: parent happy, child happy! Tactfully and carefully, do the hand-off.

This may sound callous, even cold, and it may even sting you while reading this. Many parents have the image of their little one crying at the classroom door and feeling frozen in a panic, not knowing what to do next. That is almost never the case, and if it should happen, Montessori teachers know what to do. Being informed, planning, and creating what we call a "corrective experience" can lead to a change of experience in the future. Usually, even the children who have the most trouble saying good-bye will quickly transition to new friends and will want to join in an activities and come home and share fun experiences. Do not, however, be alarmed if there is a day two, day three, and possibly more of these experiences. It will get better.

Even if parents and teachers do every-

thing 'right,' there are children that still have more serious separation anxiety issues. This disorder is not so uncommon. It affects about 3 to 4 percent of the child population and often develops after a life 'stressor' (e.g., divorce, moving to a new home, illness, death of a grandparent or pet, etc.). In acute situations, a child can experience extreme distress when away from the home or away from a parent: constant worry; inability to do anything on her own; inability to sleep separate from parents or away from home; nightmares; and may include physical symptoms (including headaches, stomach aches, etc.). This disorder can occur at any age and may vary in manifestation depending on the age and gender of one's child.

If a parent sees these symptoms, it may be helpful to seek consultation from a school psychologist or counselor to try different interventions. It may also be helpful for parents to seek help from a psychologist who specializes in childhood disorders to help work in collaboration with the school, the family, and the child. This disorder can be extremely painful for parents and children, and early intervention can be the most significant factor in changing the course of the problem for the rest of the child's life.

School experiences are memories that we carry throughout all of life. Many of these memories involve how parents help chil-

dren cope with their transitions. Don't underestimate your feelings, as parents, either – separation can be quite difficult on your end (we often underestimate the 'fears' of watching our children grow up, too!).

Whether it's your child's first experience at school or a new year for a returning student, it's a time of great excitement and change. Even good change is stressful. Having a plan, listening to your child, and working together with teachers can make it a much smoother transition for everyone. Don't forget yourself in the process. You'll be returning to, or establishing, a new routine as well. ☺

Mobile - Montessori We're On Your Site

Accepting Proposals for Training
At Your School Now For:

- Early Childhood Courses
- Elementary Level Courses



Southwestern Montessori Training Center, Incorporated

A Non-Profit Educational Organization Est. 1974
Post Office Box 310947, N.T. Station,
Denton, TX 76203 Phone/Fax: 940-566-1640
swest4smtc@aol.com
MACTE Accredited

Montessori-style Products for Elementary Classroom

Our hands-on products were designed to supplement the non-traditional classroom in History, Science, & Mathematics. All of our products come with a FREE Curriculum Guide and Supplemental Materials.

Clocca Concepts



Check our other products:

- TimeLine Scroll
- Historical Card Sets
- Mathematic Card Sets
- Science Card Sets

Coordinate Graph Curriculum

The Coordinate Graph Curriculum was designed to introduce students to the basic concepts of the coordinate graph and to the more complex concepts of the linear equation. The 3-Level Command Cards allow for hands-on multiple lessons and activities of work. This includes:

- ~19" x 19" Coordinate Graph
- ~3-Level Command Cards
- ~Nomenclature Cards
- ~2-Color coordinate wooden markers

Price \$95.00



www.cloccaconcepts.com



Montessori Graduates Where are they now?

Datev Gallagher
New Gate School
Sarasota, FL

Pictured above are Datev and her brother, Corey, also a New Gate graduate.

As I look back on how interesting it was for me to grow up in a Montessori setting and observe its influence as I grew older, I notice the effect Montessori education and the Montessori way of life has had on my general views of the world around me.

I believe I have always been an artist. I think this is something people are born with. So, as a young child it was extremely beneficial for me to learn in an environment where I could put my hands on things – where I was encouraged to discover, explore, and create. When I was younger, all I ever knew was Montessori, so I never imagined there was any other form of schooling.

A lot of people have told me I was sheltered because of growing up in such a small, gentle, and constantly supportive community and school. In many ways, I have to agree with them. When I reached middle school, I realized that there was a much bigger world outside of the small school I was attending. I realized for the first time that Montessori is a minority in the schooling world. Middle school became a confusing time, because I started to wonder if this school was really going to prepare me for the “real world,” as I’ve heard it

called so many times. Many of my friends at the time transferred to other schools hoping to find that “real world” we had heard so much about. I can’t explain what made me decide to stay at the time, but I was compelled to hold my ground.

Once I reached high school, Montessori became a very different experience for me. Once we reached that age, we no longer used the hands-on materials we did in elementary school and, instead, we got our hands-on experience by going out into the community. We did many internships, community service, and class trips as well.

For the first time in my life, I got a real sense of how big the world really is. We traveled to other cities and to other countries. We did community service for all different kinds of organizations, and as I explored, something hit me really hard – a realization that was long overdue! I never really realized how fortunate I was. For the first time, I realized that, while I comfortably moved through life, others struggled. And I hate to admit it now, but I started to resent my school. I wondered what made me so special that I deserved this pampering while others suffered – while others wished for an education as good as mine. Through my community service I worked with all kinds of kids who were just as deserving as I was, just as innocent, just as curious, and just as inquisitive but not as fortunate. I toyed with feelings of anger, sadness, resentment, confusion, and even embarrassment at

the ease with which I had attained this life.

It wasn’t until my senior year at New Gate School that I was able to finally come to terms with these facts. I started to realize the uselessness of just feeling bad about my privileges. And it was then that I saw that the privileges I had been given provided me with the greatest tools I ever could have asked for. Because of the amazing education I received and the loving and supportive community I grew up in, I feel it is my responsibility to use what I’ve learned to actually start making things better – to start improving the wrongs I see with the world. I feel empowered and unstoppable.

I have many aspirations when it comes to contributing to the world I live in. Right now, as a college student, I am focusing on growing and learning about myself. I honestly believe that the people who learn how to love and respect themselves are the people who can most effectively love and respect other human beings.

Montessori shows kids from the beginning of their development how to appreciate beauty, health, their environment, their community, and most importantly the feelings and needs of their classmates and future co-inhabitants of this earth.

Note: Datev graduated from New Gate School in 2007. She attends Florida State University, Tallahassee, FL and is beginning her senior year. Her major is Motion Picture Arts. Datev’s dad, Chris Gallagher (past Head of New Gate School), says that when he and his wife, Brigitte, were looking for schools for their two- and three-year-old children many years ago, they wanted to find a place that would allow their children to feel empowered to do and be whatever they chose – that the educational method and setting would not place limits on them with regard to perceived talents, skills, intelligence, or possibilities. When they discovered New Gate School and Montessori, they knew that they had found that place! Chris also said at several occasions such as Moving Up and Commencement Ceremonies to the student body: “Remember always – you are important, you are beautiful, and you are loved!”

— **Lorna McGrath**
The Montessori Foundation,
Associate Head of The New Gate-Field School

Have a Montessori graduate’s story? We’d love to hear from you. Contact Chelsea Howe at tcmag@montessori.org

Coming Together:

Economic Struggles Unite a Soup Kitchen, Market, Social Services, & Montessori to Serve a Community in Need

Community Montessori School Ft. Myers, Florida

Several years ago I met a young Montessori teacher at one of our international conferences. I often keep in touch with many such people because I love hearing about what they are up to. Such is the case with Cindy Venezia. She is now the Montessori Director at the Community Montessori School in Ft. Myers, FL, just 90 minutes south of Sarasota where the Foundation's headquarters are located. Cindy attended the conference in Sarasota last year and came away inspired by the keynote speaker Cynthia Burns' (Maui, Hawaii) school's greening initiative and micro-economies. I was then inspired by what Cindy put into action and asked her if I could come down and see what they had done. All I can say, after visiting with her, is that I was so wowed and thinking so hard about what I had seen that I actually missed my highway exit on the way home!

A little background before I begin.

Community Coop Ministries, INC (CCMI) was founded in 1984. Its primary mission was to provide a soup kitchen and low-cost child care. Approximately five years ago, several agencies merged together: the soup kitchen, preschool (by then in its second

year of being a Montessori school), a market, social services, and Meals on Wheels. All now come under the CCMI banner. With some government funding (not in the Montessori school), they mostly rely on private donations, well-researched grants and, a lot of sweat equity from volunteers. The population that CCMI serves falls between 150-200 percent below the poverty level.

Why Montessori?

Sarah Owens, a parent of a student where Cindy was a Montessori teacher, asked Cindy if she were interested in joining her, as she became the CEO of CCMI. Sarah is also Montessori trained and was interested in turning the existing preschool/daycare into a Montessori school. Cindy was hooked and joined Sarah in the planning stages. Cindy remembers her first tour of the facility, where five-tiered bookshelves were laden with 'stuff.' The tall shelves were soon replaced with low shelving much better suited for children of this age. Whereas, before, there wasn't a single living plant, now each of the two classes is filled with plants, fish tanks, low shelving, work mats, and baskets along with the familiar Montessori didactic manipulatives. It had become a Montessori environment.

Working with the state agencies that monitor such programs has been a process of education, Cindy tells me. They have checklists of standards, and if they don't immediately see it for what they think it should look like a little "tick mark" of deficiency is placed on the paper. Once Cindy was able to explain how and why Montessorians do things, those tick marks got erased. She's become a master at being able to translate so that these agencies' criteria are being met on Montessori terms.

The Struggles of the Children

The first year, Cindy dedicated her efforts with the first group's social and emotional development. "They weren't ready for much in the way of academics, because when you are living so far below the poverty level even the most basic skills involving gross- and fine-motor skills have to improve first. Getting them to trust the teachers and the materials, getting them to connect and make eye contact was enough of a challenge."

Most programs group 3-6 year old children together. Here, the children weren't ready to be in a primary room until at least 3^{1/2}. They were just behind. After working with them now for the second year, they've been able to back this up to 3 years and two months. They are thrilled with this huge success.

What made the biggest impact on these children?



CCMI is also a community soup kitchen. Montessori director Cindy Venezia proudly shows off the facilities

The classrooms are now set up as traditional Montessori environments.



by Margot Garfield-Anderson
Director of Public Relations
The Montessori Foundation



2010 Montessori Leadership Institute OnLine! Term 3

Sept. 18 – Dec. 10, 2010

Finding The Perfect Match: Recruit & Retain Your Ideal Enrollment

Building a World-Class Montessori School

An Overview of Montessori Principles & Curriculum from Infant/Toddler through High School

New Program in Montessori Leadership Certification

Coming
Soon!

Location: Your office or home,
on your computer!

Instructors: Tim Seldin & Sharon
Caldwell, The Montessori Foundation

**Special discount for IMC
members and multiple
attendees from the same
IMC school.**

For complete
information, visit the
Montessori Leadership
Institute wing on
our website:

www.montessori.org
or call 941-729-9565.

Art, Water, and Gardening

Cindy credits three different projects for the biggest transformations in the children. Most of these children had never been exposed to working with soil, creative writing, art materials, let alone, knowing how trees produced fruit, needed water to grow, or the names of any of the great masters of art. At first, most of the children were too afraid to touch anything for fear of being reprimanded for making a mess. But, once the programs got under way, the change in the children became apparent. Cindy remembers, months into the program, hearing some children independently reading and commenting out loud, "This is Kandinsky's art work."

Local artists taught the art programs. One memorable project involved tracing their bodies onto paper and coloring them to represent different aspects of weather. The school hosted a gallery night for the parents. At first, the parents saw them as just scribbles on paper until the idea was explained to them. It opened their eyes to the possibilities of what their children were capable of doing, thinking, and feeling.

Ten fruit trees and a small vegetable garden were planted by the children with the assistance of two groups: ECHO (Educational Concerns for Hunger Organization) and the Junior League. The Junior League actually asked to fund the vegetable garden as a part of their program to create good nutritional programs in schools.

Remember earlier when I mentioned that Cindy had been inspired by one of our keynote speakers? Well, she went back to school and told Sarah that they needed to create a business out of their trees and vegetables. Cindy describes Sarah as a visionary and this idea took hold for her.

What they decided to do was transform, and then model, their food bank into a market experience Sarah had seen in another state. In this way, people could come to the market, give the volunteers the vouchers from Social Services, and then shop. Volunteers lead clients through the aisles to select the foods that meet their individual family's needs and tastes. No longer is this seen as just a hand-out to the needy. The point is to restore the dignity of people and help them shop for the foods that they want. The market aisles and walls are adorned with baskets, dried flowers, and displays similar to what we see in stores such as Fresh Market and Whole Foods but on a much smaller scale. Local bakeries donate day-old, unsold cakes and breads, and one store even donated many dispensers with bulk-assorted jelly beans for extra treats to bring home.

As for the fresh produce sold in the market? Why, of course, the students at the Montessori school grow it! They raise, harvest, and nurture it – all while learning about local agriculture, the running of business, and tending to a garden and nature. They are learning to work with oth-

The market is modeled on the Fresh Market and Whole Foods stores. There are lovely baskets and decorations to complement the shopping experience.



ers within a community to make an impact. The lessons this project teaches the students will last a lifetime. It's all so circular, because we want our children to understand community on so many levels, and what CCMI has created and what they are doing with their children and parents speaks to this in every way that you can imagine.

These children might have otherwise fallen through the cracks. Now, they have a solid chance of transitioning into school programs on a more level playing field. The progress in their social and emotional development improves all the time, and this opens them up to succeed in the academic areas as well.

The Parents

Reaching the parents and getting them involved and invested was the final piece to making this all work. Cindy has seen, slowly but steadily, parents becoming involved in all aspects of the school. They now get some parents coming in to read to the children. This is amazing, as most of these parents have precious little free time during the day to spare. So the students have a corner in the room, where they made honorary plaques to present to parents who participate in classroom activities. Cindy sees more and more parents coming to meetings and even volunteering in the other areas that CCMI serves, such as the soup kitchen.

The Community

The children also believe in giving to other partners within their community. They sold some of the produce and some spices they ground up into powders and managed to raise \$40 in this enterprise. They presented a check for the \$40 to the United Way in a ceremony that was covered by local media.

Montessori schools strive to create community. CCMI strives to create pride in their community. The combination of the two works well. Sarah, Cindy, and their staff are on to something that empowers children and adults. Cindy invites you to contact her should you have any questions about the programs they run or how you can create a similar program in your community. You can contact Cindy at: cindy@ccmileecounty.com. ☺



Dear Cathie ... A Montessori Teacher's Perspective

by
**Cathie
Perolman**

Three Days a Week Is Not Enough

Q

My three-year-old is starting Montessori school in the fall, and they want her to go every day. The school has a three-day-a-week option, and that seems to be plenty of time in school to me. I know that very young children do advanced academic things in a Montessori school, and while I want my child to advance as quickly as she can, I don't want her under that amount of pressure every day. Is it really necessary for a child to go every day? My child is quite bright, and I am confident she will learn easily.

— A Conflicted Mom

A

Dear Mom:

The Montessori Method is all about helping children reach their maximum potential. This is done by creating an environment that is rich in developmental opportunities for young children. Children then choose activities from this smorgasbord. They try new things and develop new skills, a process which takes time and repetition. During the course of the work time, the guide invites the child to new lessons, suggests activities that they might enjoy or benefit from, and watches as they choose and complete activities of their choice. The classroom develops a social culture, where children invite others to share a table, do an activity together, have snack with a friend, sit together on the circle at group time, or play together outside. This social experience parallels real life and requires repeated experiences to master.

Maria Montessori wrote extensively about the Sensitive Periods. These are

times in a child's life when they are particularly drawn to certain activities and when learning of a certain type occurs with great joy and ease. This effortlessness will never again exist in the child's life. Yes, children will be able to learn the same skills at an older age, but never will it be this simple. The Montessori classroom maximizes these periods by allowing/encouraging children to work extensively in an area during this time. This can only occur with regular attendance and opportunities for work time in the classroom.

When most children attend full time and some children only attend part time, the social culture of the class is affected, as a part-time child cannot be fully integrated into the class. On the days he attends, he needs to make up for the time he did not attend. Thus, his time in the class is used somewhat artificially. He has to socialize with more intensity, as he has less time to do it.

This affects not only the choices he makes in the classroom, but those that the other children make as a result of his sporadic presence. He is often either more sought after than other children or somewhat ignored. Young children are just not that good at understanding time and predicting when to expect a part-time classmate and when not to. This creates a somewhat artificial social situation for the part-time child, more in keeping with part-time preschool than the Montessori environment.

Part-time attendance often has an effect on the child's academic growth as well. It is true that parents and Montessori guides want children to progress academically. This happens

naturally when children have enough time to explore all the activities in the classroom at their developmental level. When a child only comes part time, she does not have this time. Thus, she never gets to do all the activities she wishes to do.

These children choose a higher proportion of social works and more works that are new to the environment. They repeat activities less often, thus delaying the natural mastery of skills. Other part-time children opt to do the same activities every day they come, as they are too overwhelmed by the classroom to try new things. Thus, this child may need more than an average amount of adult attention to work at her developmental level.

This explains why parents of part-time children often view the Montessori classroom as mostly academic activities, placing high pressure on children. In order for these children to progress, they have to spend a higher proportion of their school day working on academic tasks. This may make the class tend toward a more teacher-directed style of Montessori that is not in keeping with the original philosophy.

While five days a week may feel like a lot to you, it is actually more predictable and comfortable for your child. Many families of beginning children do take a day off occasionally when they feel that their child needs a break. This is perfectly fine and is in keeping with the philosophy of "Follow the Child."

Some Montessori schools do offer three-day-a-week programs, but their motivation is generally to meet the requests of parents and fill their spaces. Montessori guides almost unanimously agree that a child who attends five days has a richer and more authentic and complete experience. 🌱



Cathie Perolman is an experienced Montessori guide at the 3-6 level. She is a Montessori teacher educator and publisher of educational materials. Cathie guides a 3-6 Montessori class at Nurturing Nest Montessori in Columbia, MD. She can be contacted through Tomorrow's Child at: tcmag@montessori.org



THANKS to all our standing bulk order subscribers for your support in getting this new benefit of *Tomorrow's Child* off and running!

If your school has a standing bulk order to *Tomorrow's Child*, your families and staff can get connected to *Tomorrow's Child OnLine* NOW!

Tomorrow's Child OnLine is a free, additional benefit to subscribing in bulk to *Tomorrow's Child*.

TCOL includes articles, videos, audio files, interviews and more that connect Montessori families and schools.



Contact Lorna McGrath (Director of the Family Education Center) at lornamcgrath@montessori.org for details.

Stay connected!

It's not too late for Montessori schools to place their standing bulk order of *Tomorrow's Child* for the 2010/11 school year.

See page 37 for information on benefits & special discounts.



Raising Happiness: 10 Simple Steps for More Joyful Kids and Happier Parents
by Christine Carter, Ph.D.

What do most parents say they want for their children? To be happy! So, what if happiness is a learned skill — a skill that can be practiced? Author, Christine Carter, Ph.D., Executive Director of UC Berkley's Greater Good Science Center, leads us through the most current "happiness" research. In a user-friendly format, Dr. Carter presents ten key steps that, when implemented, create a significant difference in our own and our children's happiness.

Each chapter presents one of the ten steps and supporting research with real-life examples. Dr. Carter shares her personal experiences with her own family, which brings each step to life. I loved the "Try This" sections with ideas to begin implementing immediately. For instance, "Practice Gratitude," "Put on Some Happy Tunes and Dance Around," and "Combating Perfectionism."

Although each of the ten steps is valuable, the author makes it very clear throughout the book that implementing even one of these steps will be a life-altering experience for your family. I particularly liked these three steps: "Build a Village," "Form Happiness Habits," and "Enjoy the Present Moment."

Packed with fascinating information, such as: "Children imitate their parents' emotions as early as six days old" and "Happy friends, neighbors, and siblings who live in close proximity to you (as adults) increase your odds of being happy." This book offers an inspiring opportunity to have a profound impact on the quality of the children in your life.

You can purchase this book in most bookstores as well as online. It comes in Kindle, also.

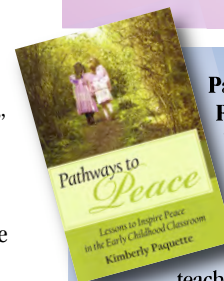
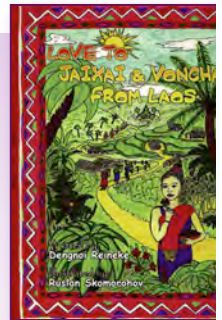
— **Reviewed by Kathy Leitch,**
Founder & Head of
The Renaissance School,
Ft. Myers, FL

Montessori Reads

Love to Jaixa & Vanchai from Laos
by Dengnoi Reineke

Dengnoi says, "This is a fairy tale about a little girl in a traditional Laotian village." The book is adorned with beautiful illustrations of landscapes and costumes. Within this children's book, there are simple Laotian words such as *village*, *love*, *bello*, etc. Dengnoi has also included some easy recipes for children to create at home or in the classroom.

If you are interested in Southeast Asia as a teacher for cultural studies or as a parent to broaden your family's understanding of cultures of the world, this would be a wonderful little book for your library.



Pathways to Peace
by Kimberly Paquette

Paquette, a certified Montessori Early Childhood teacher, became engaged in the creation of *Pathways to Peace* in graduate school. After spending several years teaching in a Montessori classroom and observing in many other Montessori classrooms, she began to wonder why there was not a curriculum for Peace Education that encompassed Montessori's philosophy for living, as well as Howard Gardner's theory of Multiple Intelligences. As part of her studies she developed this curriculum and book for teachers not only in Montessori schools but also in more conventional settings, such as church schools, home schools, and even public schools.

Pathways to Peace is specifically designed for teachers of children age 3-6 years old. However, the beauty of it is that it can be expanded to include the elementary years as

Read any good book

Please contact



Dengnoi's daughter is in her second year of Montessori school – Montessori Stepping Stones in Clemens, Michigan. Dengnoi and her husband have seen their daughter develop in so many ways. Montessori has been a wonderful experience for their family.

When you purchase this book 5 percent of the author's profit will go to Green Soul Shoes. This New York company aims to provide shoes to 300 million shoeless children worldwide. For every pair of shoes sold, GreenSoul Shoes also gives away a pair to a child in a third-world community. The shoes are made from 100 percent recycled rubber tires.

You can purchase this book from Amazon.com.

— Reviewed by Lorna McGrath

well. Because the author combines Montessori's and Gardner's ideas, the lessons that she has created appeal to a diverse group of children.

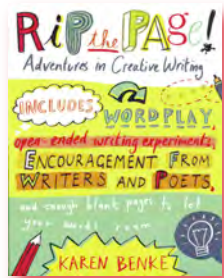
The author has divided the book into two sections. The first introduces the reader to Montessori's ideas, Gardner's theories, and research that supports the application of Peace Education. The second section actually gives the reader lesson plans which include materials needed, the purpose of the activity, the steps in presenting each lesson, and some variations and extensions to add further interest or challenge to the original presentation. The activities incorporate all areas of the classrooms from grace and courtesy to math. At the end of the book, there are several pages of resources for further development of ideas related to Peace Education.

Pathways to Peace would be an excellent resource for schools, homes, or religious communities. You can purchase this book at www.iuniverse.com/Bookstore.

— Reviewed by Lorna McGrath

Rip the Page! Adventures in Creative Writing

by Karen Benke
Published by
Trumpeter, an imprint
of Shambhala
Publications



This book is a book for young adults (8- to 12-year-olds) (although I must say that I also enjoyed the writing exercises).

The exercises in *Rip the Page!* aren't designed like a school assignment or extra-credit work. They're meant to amuse and inspire children, showing them how fun and freeing creative writing can be.

Kids who like writing, and even those who've never put pen to paper unless it was assigned, are invited to explore, share, and *Rip the Page!* out of this unique writing book.

Inside the book, you'll find:

- "Try this..." experiments to spark new ideas
- Word lists to help when young writers get stuck
- "Suddenly a story..." exercises to rouse the imagination
- Definition decoder to deepen writing knowledge
- Notes of advice from famous writers, such as Lemony Snicket, Annie Barrows, Naomi Shihab Nye, Gary Soto, Lucille Clifton, and others.

Unlike other writing guides, *Rip the Page!* encourages children to use the book anyway they choose: open to the last page and work backward or begin in the middle and move forward. Put stars by favorite ideas, cross out whatever they don't like. There are no limits to the imagination or to how kids can use this book. The author advises her readers: "There's no wrong or right way to write creatively, just your way. The only thing this book needs is your imagination." The book can be purchased at Amazon.com.

— Reviewed by Joyce St. Giermaine
Editor

Something Yummy ...

The following is a recipe I discovered while watching *The Dr. Oz Show*. It really looked like a fun recipe that children would enjoy making ... and eating!

It comes from Chef Charles Mattock, who is also known as the "Poor Chef." An interesting fun fact is that Chef Mattock happens to be the nephew of the late reggae legend Bob Marley; however, what Chef Mattock is really known for is his ability to create simple, healthy, and inexpensive family dinners ... generally under \$7.

You can find out more about him by going to: www.thepoorchef.com

Turkey Upside Down Casserole

This is one of those standbys that kids seem to love because it gets turned upside-down. If you have ground turkey, chicken, or hamburger meat and a few staples in the kitchen, you can put it together in a flash.

Ingredients

- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 1 cup sliced onion
- 1/2 lb ground turkey
- 1 10.5-oz can tomato puree
- Worcestershire sauce
- 1 (11.5-oz) can refrigerator biscuits

Directions

Preheat the oven to 350 deg F. Heat the oil in a medium-size skillet over medium heat. Add the onion and cook, stirring, until it is soft and golden, 2 to 3 minutes. Add the meat and cook, stirring and breaking it up, until browned. Pour in the tomato puree, add a dash or two of Worcestershire sauce, and stir well. Scrape the contents of the skillet into a 2-quart baking dish. Place the refrigerator biscuits side by side over the top of the meat mixture. Bake for 10 to 15 minutes, until the biscuits are browned. To serve, put a serving dish on top of the casserole and invert it, so that the biscuits are on the bottom.

Add some veggies as a side dish and you're ready to eat.

— Joyce St. Giermaine
Editor

ooks or enjoyed some great CDs lately?
Reviews welcome.
me at lornamcgrath@montessori.org.

CLASSIFIEDS

Lower Elementary Lead Teacher (VA)

We are a small, community-oriented Montessori school in Northern Virginia seeking a certified Lower Elementary lead teacher who has experience with this age level. Our ideal candidate would be someone with an excitement for the learning process and a passion for teaching who demonstrates a high level of professionalism and is a confident self-starter. Benefits include health, retirement, and tuition discounts. Please send all inquiries to: montessoriholmesrun@yahoo.com

Primary Lead Teacher, Lower Elementary Teacher, Toddler Teacher (VA)

Qualifications: AMS/AMI certified

Benefits: 30 Days paid vacation, paid training. (Working on health)

Description of School Community: We are actively looking for a certified toddler, primary or Lower El teacher for our dynamic and authentic Montessori program. We are a year round and extended Montessori program. We offer parent information and support groups and family cultural activities. We offer a Dual Language/Spanish and English program. Music, Art and Sciences are fully developed in the classroom.

Our families and staff are a diverse group and committed to a Zero Waste Policy, a Healthy Food First Policy and have developed a culture of giving to others. Our first campus is beautiful urban campus and we are looking to open 2nd campus in a heavily forested area in the near suburbs. Both programs are small with around 70 students. Ten-month contracts or twelve month contracts are available.

If you would like to join a new school where your contributions are deeply meaningful and valued, please consider contacting us.

Central Montessori School

Contact: Anita Pishko
323 N. 20th Street, Richmond, VA 23223_
Phone: 804-447-7493
Fax: 804-447-7494 • E-mail: centralmontessorischool@comcast.net
Web: centralmontessori.org

Primary Montessori Teacher in the California Bay Area

Montessori School of Los Altos seeks an experienced AMI or AMS trained Montessori Teacher with Site Director permit to join our international team.

Qualifications include: BA degree, Site Director permit, Montessori diploma, excellent command of English, French or Mandarin desirable.

Founded in 1972, our school offers the classic Montessori primary curriculum, complemented by foreign languages, Orff music, dance and many multicultural activities. We offer excellent salaries and generous vacation and benefit packages.

Inquiries and resumes may be sent to Founder and Director Hannelore Engelman at h-engelman@earthlink.net

Middle School Lead Teacher (FL)

South Walton Montessori Academy, located in Santa Rosa Beach, FL, provides a unique learning center for children and families of Walton County and surrounding areas. Our campus is on the shore of Tucker Bayou in the historic community of Point Washington, next to Eden State Gardens. SWMA is looking to hire a lead teacher to lead the expansion of our middle school. The ideal candidate will have prior experience as lead teacher of a middle school classroom, a contagious love of learning, and exceptional leadership qualities.

Ideal candidates will have:

- A B.A. or B.S
- Montessori Certificate
- 5 years experience teaching and/or working with middle school aged children
- The ability to learn new skills quickly and to adapt easily to suit the needs to the environment or situation
- The attitude of a team player
- Leadership experience in the classroom or in school administration

Ideal candidates will also demonstrate the following qualities:

- Highly organized
- The ability to create and develop systems, processes, and curriculum components and set up a new classroom
- Kind, caring, and peaceful nature
- Excellent communication skills
- Interpersonal skills and the ability to relate to and work with a wide variety of people and audiences (other teachers, students, parents, prospective families, etc.)

Please send cover letter and resume indicating your interest and experience to bethbrock@mac.com

Head of School (CA)

Marin Montessori School (www.marinmontessori.org) seeks a head of school who is an experienced, progressive educational leader – a person excited to lead with energy, joy and inspiration. Founded in 1963, serves 230 students from toddler age through age 15 on two campuses. The Toddler through Upper Elementary programs are on its Corte Madera campus overlooking San Francisco Bay, and the Junior High School program is currently located in leased space on the grounds of St. Vincent's School in San Rafael, ten minutes from the main campus.

The next head will lead a school that is poised to achieve a position, nationally and internationally, of an educational model of excellence. The successful candidate needs to be inspired—and inspiring—to make this possibility a reality. MMS seeks an experienced, good-humored, successful, energetic school leader who will enthusiastically embrace and support the MMS mission and community.

Interested candidates should send a Resume, Letter of Interest and Educational Philosophy to:

Jane Foote or Jim Munger
Independent Thinking
it@independent-thinking.com
617-332-3131 (east coast office)
707-775-8943 (west coast office)

Head of School (MD)

The Tidewater School is looking for an exceptional, experienced Head of School who is committed to Montessori education and who will lead the school to its next level of growth. Tidewater is a small, non-profit, primary school providing a unique learning environment/pre-school through 5th grade. We are located at 120 Cox Road, Huntingtown, MD 20639

The Head of School will be responsible for all aspects of school operation including but not limited to: overall organization of the school; maintaining a balanced budget while gaining access to new revenue streams for expansion; maintaining a curriculum that provides an exceptional learning experience for the individual child; support and empowerment of teachers and staff; seamless and transparent communications; planning of current and future activities; strong parent and constituent relations; ongoing public relations efforts including appropriate channels of social media; foster interagency relations; building and grounds maintenance and safety.

BA/BS undergraduate; MA in Business or Education and 5 – 10 years experience required. Business management skills are essential/strong academic credentials a plus. Qualified individuals may submit cover letter and resume to carol.dunlap50@yahoo.com

New School Openings (TX)

Seeking experienced (AMI, AMS, MACTE) teachers for new school opening in Fall 2010 - Primary, Toddler, Infant, and Assistant Head of School. Come work as a team with an experienced Head of School (30+ yrs.) who knows how to mentor and lead professional individuals to make a positive difference in young children's lives. Take the first step to joining Little Marvels Montessori in Plano, Texas by sending a resume and cover letter to psm@lmmontessori.com.

Calendar

September 18 - December 10, 2010

Montessori Foundation

Montessori Leadership Institute: Term 3
(800) 655-5843 (see inside front cover)
www.montessori.org

October 22 - 24, 2010 - AMS

2010 Fall Conference

San Diego, CA (212) 358-1250
www.amshq.org

November 4 - 7, 2010

Montessori Foundation & IMC

14th Annual International Conference
Sarasota, FL (800) 632-4121

www.montessori.org
margot@montessori.org

February 18 - 21, 2011 - NAMTA

2011 Annual Adolescent Conference

Long Beach, CA (440) 834-4011
www.montessori-namta.org

March 17 - 21, 2010

Montessori Foundation & IMC

8th Annual West Coast Conference

San Jose, CA (800) 632-4121
www.montessori.org
margot@montessori.org

March 24 - 27, 2011 - AMS

2011 Annual Conference

Chicago, IL (212) 358-1250
www.amshq.org

If you have a conference or event you'd like to promote, please email information to: tcmag@montessori.org.

To place an ad, please email the ad to us at: tcmag@montessori.org.
Missed the deadline for this publication? You can still get your ad online.
The classified advertising rate is \$2/word with a \$50 minimum.

Now There's Three Ways to Purchase *Tomorrow's Child*: The magazine with benefits!

The Montessori Foundation always strives to help schools and parent organizations provide the most cost effective ways to get *Tomorrow's Child* magazine into the hands of parents. At the same time, in our effort to conserve natural resources and save trees, we'd like to introduce *Tomorrow's Child*, the electronic version.



1 Standing Bulk Orders for 2010/11

Same prices as last year!

Tomorrow's Child magazine is the best way for schools to help parents stay connected on key issues in Montessori. Articles on parenting, research, how Montessori is done internationally, schools showcasing their uniqueness, graduate achievements and valuable calendar of events make this one of the most widely read Montessori resources worldwide.

Administrators who put the cost of the magazine into their tuition understand that the benefits far exceed the minimal cost. When parents are informed and embrace the time tested & proven results that a Montessori education can bring to their families they will thank you!

We greatly discount the print version to our schools. In the US a standing bulk order costs just \$15.50 per family per year. 50 minimum in a standing bulk order. That's just \$750 annually! (Should your school have less than 50 families call our main office at 800 655 5843 to get approval for a smaller quantity.)

*Standing Bulk Order subscribers will also have access to Tomorrow's Child OnLine (see inset).**

2 Individual Orders (Print)

You may purchase our regular print version, same as always or you may sign up for the electronic version by using this form or by going through our publication center's online bookstore at www.montessori.org.

Those with current print subscriptions will continue to receive the publication mailed to their addresses.

3 Individual Orders (Electronic)

When you subscribe to the electronic version you will be emailed a link to *Tomorrow's Child OnLine*'s parent resource center along with a user name and password.

Remember, the electronic version is not for our current standing bulk order subscribers, but for those who wish to have an individual subscription sent electronically.

Each time we publish an issue, you will receive an email notifying you that the electronic version is ready for you to access through TCOL.

Log on, go to the TCOL page and you're ready to read. Just turn the pages using the arrow. It's that easy and sounds just like you are flipping pages in a print magazine. *Electronic subscribers will also have access to Tomorrow's Child OnLine (see inset)*.*

Tomorrow's Child OnLine

**Free Benefit for Standing Bulk Order & Electronic Subscribers*

Tomorrow's Child OnLine, the parent resource center provides you with many other free articles and video presentations on effective parenting and how to incorporate a Montessori way of life into your daily family routines. Hosted by the Foundation's Parent Education Director, Lorna McGrath, there are many short video clips on critical issues of parenting. This added benefit is available to bulk subscribers and electronic subscribers.

Contact Information:

Make checks payable to:
The Montessori Foundation.

Mail to: 19600 E. State Road 64,
Bradenton, FL 34212.

Fax: 941 745 3111.
Schools needing invoices, please
contact dondinsmore@montessori.org

The Foundation always strives to keep printing costs under control as well as conserve resources and, therefore, we no longer keep an inventory of back issues nor large quantities of the most current issue. We will always try and fulfill new standing bulk orders with the most currently released issue. If that isn't possible, we'll start your order with the next one in the cycle and pro-rate your order.

Order Form



Tomorrow's Child ...

Beginning in September 2010, *Tomorrow's Child* will be published four times per year: September, November, January, and April.

**Special Sale ...
While Supplies Last!**



For your convenience, we continue to accept payment by credit card: Visa, Mastercard, or American Express.

Please remember: *Tomorrow's Child* is a copyright-protected publication. Duplication of the magazine in any form without permission is prohibited by law and prevented by your integrity.

Standing Bulk Orders (SBO) for 2010/11 school year

☐ For USA Orders _____ subscriptions X \$15.50 US funds **TOTAL DUE** _____

Your SBO will start with the September 2010 issue (subject to availability). SBO's are for schools with 50 or more families. Schools with fewer than 50 families need to call our main office at 800-655-5843 for approval. Schools requesting a PO or located outside of the USA please call 800-655-5843 or email dondinsmore@montessori.org for pricing information.

Individual Subscriptions: Print Version

I would like an individual subscription starting with the most current issue.

☐ For USA Orders _____ subscription X \$30.00 per year, US funds

☐ For Outside USA Orders _____ subscription X \$45.00 per year, US funds

TOTAL DUE _____

Individual Subscriptions: Electronic Version

☐ Yes, please send me the electronic version of *Tomorrow's Child* magazine. I understand I will need to provide a unique email address that will accept the notices announcing a new issue is ready to be read.

For anywhere, worldwide _____ subscription X \$20.00 per, US funds

TOTAL DUE _____

Special Combined Issue ... On Sale Now!!!

Our special double issue that combines our two most popular publications: *Montessori 101: What Every Montessori Parent Should Know* and *A Guided Tour of the Montessori Classroom*. 72 pages with more than 200 pictures.

Montessori 101: Special Expanded Version

	1-34 copies	35+ copies
USA	\$15 Now \$7 (plus s/h)	\$10 Now \$5 (plus s/h)
Outside USA	\$15 Now \$7 (plus s/h)	\$10 Now \$5 (plus s/h)

#Copies _____ x General Price \$ _____ = **TOTAL DUE** _____

Credit Card Number: _____ Expiration Date: _____

Email Address (please print): _____

Name on Card: _____

Shipping address: *(For bulk orders, couriers such as FEDEX and UPS cannot deliver to a PO Box)*

Contact Person's Name: _____

School Name: _____

Mailing Address: _____

City: _____ State: _____ Country: _____ Zip Code: _____

Daytime phone number in-case we cannot reach you by email: (We never sell your information. But if we have a question regarding your credit card we will call.) _____



www.nienhuis.com

**Quality you can
count on.**

In a tradition that spans over 80 years, we have consistently focused on one major aspect: the quality of our products. This combination of quality and educational value has led to a product line that sets the global standard in every respect. And because of our constant product development, our product range is continually enhanced with new, high value products that naturally appeal to children and therefore contribute to a responsible development of the child as an individual. That essence is the heart of every Nienhuis product. For instance, our mathematical material. These items perfectly reflect the good sense of quality in everything we produce. Quality you can count on.

Nienhuis
MONTESSORI

Nienhuis Montessori. The global standard.

140 E. Dana Street, Mountain View, CA 94041-1508 T 1-800-942-8697 or 1-650-964-2735 F 1-650-964-8162 E info@nienhuis-usa.com

Tomorrow's Child

A Publication of The Montessori Foundation
19600 E State Road 64 • Bradenton, FL 34212-8921

Non-Profit Org
U. S. Postage
PAID
St. Petersburg, FL
PERMIT # 597

New: Elementary!

The Center for Guided Montessori Studies (CGMS) now offers an IMC-recognized teacher training program for ages 6-12. Like our 18-month Primary certification program, this new 30-month Elementary program offers the ability to earn your certification with low residency requirements. All of our programs are designed to meet IMC standards, which meet or exceed the quality of most traditional courses.

CGMS students learn in collaborative online groups, spending an average of 10-15 hours a week working under the guidance of experienced teacher trainers. In their internship phase, students receive continuous support while gaining the practical experience essential for classroom success. CGMS students learn and retain more without abandoning their jobs, families, and friends!

*The quality of this
Montessori distance learning
program is exceptional!*

— Valerie Hannum, Principal
Kingston, NY

CGMS currently offers the following programs:

Teacher Certification

- Primary level (3-6 years old)
- Elementary level (6-12 years old)

Introductory course for assistants, administrators and parents

- Classroom Leadership

Professional development

- Special needs
- Visual arts and music
- Mathematics

Advanced courses for school heads and administrators

- Building a World-Class Montessori School*
- Finding the Perfect Match: how to recruit and retain your ideal enrollment*

* Program offered in collaboration with the Montessori Foundation.



Graduates from CGMS
teacher training programs
receive a certificate from
the International
Montessori Council.



The Center for
**GUIDED
MONTESSORI
STUDIES**

For more information please contact us at

info@guidedstudies.com

www.guidedstudies.com

1-888-344-7897